Introduction

Observatorium came into being as a result of conversations about building, exhibiting and perception that took place between three artists. Geert van de Camp, Andre Dekker and Ruud Reutelingsperger are artists of very different characters, but all three are concerned with the subject of space in relation to the individual; in other words, with how someone forms a picture of the world in relation to himself or herself. To probe that relationship, the artists sometimes decide to introduce a disrupting factor into a landscape or an urban situation. The intrusive element, which the artists usually refer to as a sculpture, presents a space where people can take the time to immerse themselves in observation and reflection. Observatorium's greatest aspiration is to get people to shed their daily preoccupations for a little while, and take in their surroundings, their planet.

Ideally, the sculpture will provide a focus, a point of arrival and of redirection; it gives the countryside or town a space and a symbol, something that invites and stimulates people into action or contemplation. If the art can accomplish anything, then it is above all to create time and space for attention – attention and curiosity towards the outside world, towards what surrounds us and towards to the interior resonances we experience. It is work that highlights the imponderability of the world around us.

Observatorium's curiosity is especially piqued by the worked earth, and by how people together make it what it is. The artists share a passion for the cultivated wilderness of the Netherlands; for the way the people in this country bring forth waterways, industrial zones, motorways, amusement parks, rationalized farm boundaries and urban extensions, blending the new creations into an existing, fluid landscape as though painting wet into wet. They are fascinated by the way we jointly parcel out the land surface into a diversity of utility and pleasure, of composition and colour. This is the area in which the three artists work together. Whether it amounts to culture, only time will tell.

Origin

In 1993, the artist Geert van de Camp made a number of large, collapsible sculptures – enough to fill a theatre auditorium. Andre Dekker, a graphic artist, took up residence in these sculptures, and worked in the theatre making drawings and writing. The painter Ruud Reutelingsperger visited the resulting exhibition, and invited his two fellow artists to make an environment for his paintings. All three artists were occupied with the subject of space – one to construct it, another to occupy it and the third to exhibit in it. The building, the sculpture and use of space coalesced into a single installation.

That is the essence of a work of art by Observatorium: to make a building or a domain where people can stay a while, and which concretizes an idea, a wish or a symbolism. The building or domain is in this sense a piece of sculpture, but it is also a space where you can do or see something, or just slow down and partake in all that goes along with stillness, such as contemplation, memory and awareness. The process is at its most productive and exciting when it takes place outdoors. The exterior is unpredictable and unrefined, but at the same time vulnerable and subject to countless rules and regulations. Art's finest calling is outdoors, but Observatorium aims to turn the outward-directed gaze inwards.

Between the artists, conversations take place in which personal fantasies are compared and combined. Ideas arise in the space between the individual characters – ideas about art in landscapes and in towns. That is Observatorium's field of work. The overlapping of three auras constitutes a common denominator: time and space for attention. It is a state of mind that we take for granted in a museum or even in a garden – but not on a motorway, an industrial estate or at a sports event. Yet that is the kind of territory in which Observatorium chooses to work.

How, people often wonder, does it come about that three artists decide to work together? The answer is generally: that is how the world works. Everybody works together. And then the doubters object, "but artists are individualists aren't they? They need as much personal space as they can get."

The truth is that not all artists need a lot of personal space for their imagination flourish, and some prefer to cooperate with others on creating a richer imaginary world than each of them could muster individually. Amid the complexity of the social surroundings, their goal is to give some persistence to their fantasies and dreams, and to test their ideas against those of others before a design process commences.

Geert says, "What we make is often a *pars pro toto*. We build objects, we make points, in which you can see a reflection of the environment, as though in a distorting mirror. We designed a lookout point and a small park with a pavilion on the noise bund that separates the isolated, newly-built, inner-city housing estate Nieuw Terbregge from the A20 motorway. Later, we expanded the design to include a memorial to the operations in which Allied aircraft dropped food supplies for the starving population of Holland in the final weeks of the War in 1945. The pavilion looks like a house built against a dyke, an archetype of Dutch vernacular architecture; in fact it accommodates motorway maintenance vehicles and encloses a garden within the park."

Ruud says, "Our strength is in creating lively public spaces, and in devising a programme of uses for the commissioned work. For example, we were asked to design a demarcation zone for the Zollvereinpark in Essen, Germany; on our own initiative, we created a domain with freely programmable uses, dedicated to individual initiatives as well as the reception of visitors. If nobody uses the work we have made, we consider it unfinished. Observatorium aims to keep things lively, and we like it when people modify our sculpture or add to it. The entrance lodge could double as a private exhibition space with a private garden for encounters; but maybe it will remain no more than a pastiche or a landmark. It's a space that give Zollverein an opportunity to show its generosity: it can make it available to private initiatives."

Andre says, "We make sculptures, and we create opportunities for people to use them. But they are also spaces whose most important functions are stillness and reflecting on the world you have just left. For example, we built a structure of steel tubing on a slag heap in the Ruhr, turning it into an Acropolis, a place where people can take time to look out over the Ruhr landscape, day or night. Designing means, among other things, recognizing the mystery and the perfection of a place and leaving it intact. We made the *Mount of Silence* in the conviction that the empty hill ought to be left empty. Our design consisted of preserving that empty space. The *Hallenhaus* landmark is a symbol of the conservation of emptiness."

Chapter 1

Time and Space for Attention
New York, 1997
Dwelling for Seclusion, Snug Harbor Cultural Center, Staten Island, New York
Collected Reflections, Art in General, New York

Time and space for attention
Art needs a spectator. Creating time and space for attention means giving, through the work of art, ample time and space to the spectator. The exhibition space takes on the nature of a dwelling, an opportunity for meaning to arise in the course of a prolonged, uninterrupted stay.

"Never is he more active than when he does nothing; never is he less alone than when he is by himself."
The Roman philosopher Cato, quoted in Hanna Arendt's *Vita Activa* (Amsterdam 2002)

Antecedents

How can an artist get around the ephemerality of an exhibition? In the early days of their cooperation, Geert van de Camp, Andre Dekker and Ruud Reutelingsperger transformed galleries such as De Vaalserberg in Rotterdam into shelters for seclusion, in which visitors could utilize the available time and space as they saw fit. What mattered to Observatorium was to create a space that was not only about the artistic intentions of the three artists but was also about what was going on in the minds of their "guests" – about what would occupy the attention of someone spending 24 hours in solitude. Observatorium wished to make the perception of art, the spectator's role (beauty being in the eye of the beholder), into an intrinsic part of the installation. The galleries were fitted out for people to stay, and each guest was provided with food, bedding, a questionnaire and 24 hours of privacy. The recipe used by Observatorium consisted (as it still does) of 1 part space, 1 part time and 1 part observation. To do justice to the last of these ingredients, the guest's responses to the questionnaire and the photographs and drawings they made were collected in an archive. Passages from the archived information were read out on conclusion of the exhibition.

***Dwelling for Seclusion* (New York)**
Following 24 hours spent in isolation, Mary said, "I need to do that more often in my life, to take big pieces of time." Why has the wish to make sculpture that commands big pieces of time developed into such an important theme for Observatorium? *Dwelling for Seclusion*, a pavilion erected in the gardens of Snug Harbor Cultural Center on Staten Island, New York City, arose from the desire to place art at the service of an individual experience of quietness, seclusion and prolonged observation. This time it was in a dedicated domain instead of an art gallery. A six-month accommodation grant enabled the group of three collaborating artists (not yet formally known as Observatorium) to address the three ingredients – space, time and attention – with precision and wholeheartedness. Space was no longer confined by the walls of a gallery, but was now an isolated building in rural surroundings. Time was no longer limited to exhibition opening hours, but was marked by the rising and setting of the sun. And the guest's recorded thoughts about the work and the situation were not merely collected or read out, but formed exhibits in an art gallery.

Pilgrimage
A New Yorker wrote about the journey from his Manhattan home to *Dwelling for Seclusion* as follows. "I took the ferry across the river. Once on Staten Island, walked along sidewalks which became increasingly dilapidated the further I travelled from the centre. Then I reached the fence of Snug Harbor and entered the grounds. I had left the city, the roads and the buildings of the complex behind me, and here was this wonderful *Dwelling for Seclusion*." His detailed travelogue could easily be interpreted as a pilgrim's tale: leaving the city, crossing the water, entering a domain, leaving everything behind and finding quiet and solitude. What he did not know was that Observatorium's design was an outcome of their study of the architectural theories published by the monk Dom Hans van der Laan.

Articulation of space
Architectonic Space by Van der Laan underlay two features of the *Dwelling for Seclusion*: the articulation of space, and the proportions of the fabric. The guest had crossed several boundaries in progress from the everyday world, and the building had boundaries of its own. Entering the core from outside involved stepping up from the surrounding field onto the platform where the pavilion stood, and going into the entrance hall. From the hall, the guest went through the door into the corridor and along it to the main space. Behind that lay the darkest room and the kitchen. The kitchen adjoined an open courtyard which provided some contact with the park the guest had just left behind. In many respects it was like a one-person cloister, with three rooms surrounding a courtyard: sanitary facilities, a bedroom and a studio. It was a variant on Van der Laan's articulation of a building into a cella, court and domain, and it resembled the only house Van de Laan ever built. That house, Villa Naalden in Best (NL), has been described as "a

classic dwelling around a courtyard, fringed by groups of piers and with a small, articulated hall as a living room."

Proportions

The bookcases share the proportions of all Observatorium's constructions. They are modular, simple, multi-purpose and, despite these pragmatic attributes, full of symbolism. The construction method is simple, lightweight and inexpensive, but it makes it possible to erect pavilions or other structures which are stable. It has the symbolism of a mental space – an empty library (the promise of knowledge) with room for the user to fill the shelves with his own experiences and insights. The bookcase is a serendipitous invention, a discovery not deliberately sought after.

The wall, in Van der Laan's architectural theory, is a human artifact that we use to enclose and exclude space. The thickness of the wall is as much a part of a house as the space it circumscribes. In the monk's harmonious architecture, the refinement of the proportions is visually obvious, and the wall thickness that is visible around windows and doorways is an intrinsic part of the dimensional relationships. Quite a few of Van der Laan's buildings have walls that are 40 cm thick. How could we use a huge thickness like this in a little pavilion? Our conclusion was to make the wall effectively hollow. For a hollow wall to be sufficiently rigid, it needs transverse members; and that led to the idea of a bookcase. The quest had been for a structural solution, yet the outcome was sculptural symbolism: a house awaiting knowledge. Moreover, the shelves opened inwards in some places and outwards in others; the latent library was an exterior as well as interior phenomenon.

A hut of ones own

The New York guests were invited to take up residence in an empty library and to fill the shelves with their own findings. One by one that summer, they became part of a freestanding sculpture with a human being in it. Visiting members of the public walked gingerly around the bookcases, cautious about disturbing the resident hermit. The photographs, drawings, films and texts that were left behind were taken to the Manhattan gallery Art in General and exhibited there. The gallery space was divided into two by a wall of cupboard units. A rotating bookcase gave admittance to the Reading Room with Collected Reflections. Here, too, it was left to the individual visitor to close the door and give himself or herself over to perusing the reading matter in solitude.

The gentle art of settling

We had gold dust on our hands, as our American friends put it; we had tapped into a rich vein of potential imagery. The work drew attention from the New York art world, was warmly reviewed in the New York times and was the subject of a long personal reflection in Metropolis. The *Dwelling* was continually occupied by one guest after another (indeed, we almost sold it) and offers of exhibitions followed. All in all, it was not bad for a group of artists just starting out. But success in the context of the art world was not what prompted us to establish Observatorium as a foundation when we returned to Rotterdam; it was the discovery that our shared predilection for space, and the opportunity to create relative freedom in the park, allowed us to create a model in miniature for the world.

Henceforth, the focus would no longer be on making objects or on proposing ideas, but on participating in the culture of our dwelling on Earth, on being pioneers. It was on settling the earth, making places, creating space – not space to live or to work, but to play, to ponder and to daydream. Our "observatory" would not be a scientific facility for studying the cosmos, but a place dedicated to perception of our own world and our place within it.

The *Dwelling for Seclusion* was a rewarding experience for the guests, rather than being a salable work of art (or however you might describe it). The guest experienced the absence of the self in an inland sea of time. Not one guest discovered himself or the Other in himself; everyone described it in terms of such phenomena as warmth, wind, comfort, emptiness or time – free time. The availability of 1

part space plus 1 part time prompted a sense of gratitude. Many guests thought mistakenly that it was an act of generosity on the part of the artists. “You are responsible for your own experience,” S. Erhardt wrote in Observatium’s publication *De Observant II.*

[contributed article]

The Wooden Blocks of Dom Hans van der Laan
Tom Maas, 1996

The work of priest/architect Dom Hans van der Laan (1904-1991) is rich and bountiful. This is not what you would say on seeing his austere buildings or reading one of the few books he wrote. They are both free of any superfluousness, down to the last detail or the last word. Van der Laan hoped to reach two goals through his sobriety: to be as exact as possible, and to be as essential as possible. The essence of his architecture had to be patent to everyone and for all times. Yet his work leaves room for countless interpretations. Or should we say that this space is deliberately left empty, by imposing limitations on form and vocabulary? The space for interpretation is also an outcome of Van der Laan changing his viewpoint a number of times. Initially the law of proportion which he termed the “Plastic Number” stood foremost, the development of a new kind of Golden Section. Later he replaced this by his Architectonic Space, which involved establishing an inseparable bond between inside and outside. His interests in his latter years turned to the character of forms – of how rods, blocks and plates “stand”, “lie” or “sit”.

All these exercises of Dom van der Laan shared a common thread. The background of each theory is in each case the interaction between nature and culture. This background is a useful starting point for this brief introduction to Van der Laan’s theoretical work.

Nature comprises a vast abundance of colours, shapes, sizes, space and so on – an abundance too great to enumerate or grasp. Against this boundless abundance of nature, the works of mankind and of human culture seem relatively insignificant and artificial. This is inevitable, in Van der Laan’s view, because what people make is always an adaptation of nature. “There is nothing that we can truly make ourselves, for our making is always the transformation of a natural thing.” Nature is the only solid ground we have, the only objective basis for everything we make and the wider background to our artifacts.

The starting point is the “natural datum”. It gives us ideas about turning that datum into something. The resulting artifact inspires in turn our mental capacities to explore further. This is how we learn by doing. It is this process that engenders our culture, ideally speaking, and that brings nature to its ultimate perfection. To Dom van der Laan, culture and nature are a duality; they are not mutually exclusive but complement each other.

To get some grasp on the abundance of what is in human terms unlimited nature, mankind cultivates a limited range of tones within a scale: colours are assigned names, measurements are in terms of named units and so on. It is in the act of doing that we arrive at these classifications. They are not “invented” in an abstract way and imposed on nature, but they come about in interaction with the natural datum. The classifications are initially coarse and approximate, but grow more refined as becomes possible and useful.

Mankind can, through the cultivation of his limitations, gain ever more insight into the relative unboundedness of nature. These is no culture without nature; and conversely, it is culture that makes nature comprehensible and perhaps even visible to us. Van der Laan regarded this “making visible” not only as a task of science but analogously as one of art. He dismissed artists who are preoccupied solely with their own inner life as “pathetic”, the expression of such introspection being a blind alley. Art can only arise in confrontation with the “natural datum”.

“Form,” Van der Laan wrote, “is something we can only perceive against a background without form, and in the first instance that background is the formless space of nature.” This form can in turn become the background to a subsequent refinement.

If architecture is concerned with making space, the awareness of inside and outside, comprehensible and tangible, with distinguishing what we make – the walls – from the space that results between these walls, this raises the question of how we can make that distinction clear. Questions of this nature were the first to occupy Van der Laan in the early period of his career as an architect; and in particular, the question of what dimensions the human eye can distinguish.

Van der Laan was fond of turning to the realm of everyday work for answers to his questions. One of his favourite examples of how people distinguish dimensions was the screening of gravel. The building process uses a range of gravel sizes from coarse to fine; that does not mean that every grain in a given batch is of equal size, but that they all fall within certain margins. If a certain grain exceeds those margins, then it falls into a finer or coarser grade. Similar considerations apply to the sorting of fruit or of eggs – in fact, to everything we distinguish by eye. We say things are of the same size not because they exactly identical but because they appear sufficiently similar; together they form a specific dimensional type. Once a certain margin is exceeded, we speak of a larger or smaller dimensional type.

Van der Laan was interested to discover whether this type of classification had a certain inherent regularity, whether there was a mechanism inherent in our perception of difference. His conclusion, partly on the grounds of empirical tests and partly on the grounds of mathematical logic, was affirmative: there was a constant relationship between successive dimensional types. He termed this relationship, when expressed numerically, the Plastic Number, thereby suggesting that this number related to ratios between three-dimensional or plastic forms and sizes.

As a way of experimenting with his findings, Van der Laan made three sets of “toy blocks” in the course of his life. The first box contained cylindrical rods in a succession of lengths determined by the Plastic Number. He designated this conceptual aid as his Abacus. While a conventional abacus is an aid to counting, Van der Laan’s Abacus is an aid to measuring.

The second set of blocks he termed a Morphoteque. It contained rectangular blocks of which not only the length but also the width ascended in a systematic fashion. This principle yielded a variety of shapes: compact blocks whose length, breadth and height were of similar size, long bars whose length was of a much larger type than the other two dimensions, and plates whose height was much smaller than the other two dimensions. It could be said that, at this stage of his research, Van der Laan was more occupied with the spatial aspects of architecture than in the case of the Abacus.

It is this Morphoteque which Observatorium has reconstructed, although on a much larger scale, at a different order of magnitude. The makers, Geert van de Camp, Andre Dekker and Ruud Reutelingsperger, acted wholly in the spirit of Van der Laan. “Children play with wooden blocks,” Van der Laan wrote in his book *Architectonic Space*, “in order to open up their understanding of plastic reality. It appears that people at a later stage of life need a similar aid to penetrate to the full depth of that reality, especially architects in the practice of their craft.”

A third set of blocks, which Van der Laan created in the latter years of his life, has remained nameless. As with the Morphoteque, these blocks vary in height, length and breadth; but in this case, unlike the Morphoteque, the volume of each block is the same. It is as though you were to take an identical block of clay, knead it into a different shape and flatten opposite faces to produce a rectangular block (“square it up” as Van der Laan put it). You could make it tall and thin (“standing”), elongated and flat (“lying”) or more equal in its dimensions (“sitting”). In this stage of his development, Van der Laan was no longer researching merely the sizes of things, and not especially the proportions of blocks, plates and rods in themselves, but the characteristics of the latter forms in relation to one another. He used these forms to make sculptural compositions; in architectural terms, ensembles of buildings, ensembles like little cities which stand out against the space of the surrounding natural landscape. And this completes the circle: what man makes is, as it were, given back to nature. If all is well, this does not

involve occupying or consuming ever more space, but creating space and making it visible, tangible and comprehensible. The *Observatory* may be regarded as a testbed for investigation of how space can be created. It is not the blocks, plates or bars that matter but the space that results between and around them. Just as music makes silence audible, the *Observatory* makes space tangible.

Preconception of a box

A friend told me she had something exciting to tell me. Then she walked away. This was the first time I heard of Observatorium. Later, she said it was this place to go and stay overnight, for twenty-four hours. There are no windows and no furniture, some furniture maybe, but it's sparse, a couple of padded blocks, and these artists made it, and the idea is that you stay here in isolation for a night, a day and a night, it's about introspection and you will just love it, I really think you should do it, you would love it. I asked if it was some room within some building. She smiled, said it wasn't a building. Then she left again.

I spent the day wondering why she would think I would want to stay in a box. A few days later, she filled me in on the details and gave me a little write-up the artists had written to explain their project/ art/ installation/ experience. I read the write-up many times. I became wildly intrigued. I still did not (nor do I) fully understand the project. But was convinced I could not truly understand this box experience without doing my time in the box. It was clear that this was a unique project. The write-up says the sizes of the box were based on a Dutch architect's theories of proportions. How could I refuse.

I am scheduled to enter at noon on Wednesday, October first. My calender shows this is a new moon. It will be a dark night. Will the padded blocks have profound influence? Will I be Pozzo-babbling at them by midnight? I have spent time solo before, and I know something of it's power, but never in a controlled environment. Never in a work of art. I imagine sensory deprivation/ stimulation. I imagine licking the walls, I imagine extreme boredom. I imagine extreme focus. I am already a bit intimidated. This is good.

The fewer toys (tools) of creation I bring, the more intense the experience will be. Yet I want to bring all my toys, I haven't decided. I appreciate some of my friends' paintings, that hang on my apartment walls more than the paintings and sculptures I've enjoyed in museums. This is because I have spent time with my friends' paintings and not with those of the masters. Brief and shallow looks at art provided brief and shallow understandings. I am hoping to gain something from the art, from the box's interior: from Geert's blocks and Ruud's paintings and Dekker's writing.

And yet, as I could spend eternity with Mondrian's later works and never see them (for I am not literate in/ to his style and seem incapable of self-learning it), so too perhaps I may see nothing in the box's interior's art. In which case it will be just me and Time. Since I signed up, I have stopped whining about how I have no time. Time has already sprouted new connotations. I am expecting Time. I will give Time a padded block to sit on (what else can you offer Time?). I hope we all get along – me, Time and Me.

Could be a deep experience, good or bad.
Could be bogus.
Depends on me.
Can't wait to find out.

Chapter 2

Otium – Negotium
Klaaswaal, 1998
Hoeksche Waard Observatory, Klaaswal
Collected Findings, Villa Alckmaer/CBK, Rotterdam

Context: the AIR/Southbound programme on the future of spatial planning in the southern wing of the Randstad.

Otium – Negotium
An *Observatory* is a paradoxical space into which you withdraw in order to determine your relationship to the world. Perception of the surroundings is impossible without a gaze into the inner self. Isolation is a form of participation.

[quotes]
The cultural landscape is in a certain sense a "work landscape", in which expression is given to *negotium* [economy]. The addition of *otium* [leisure] in the form of public cultural programmes is limited and is subsidiary to utility, and its functional character is not expressed in explicit architectural terms.
Clemens M. Steenbergen, *Ontwerpen met landschap*, Bussum, 2008

Today it is essential that the question of the event landscape be addressed –and not the question of land art underlying museographic debates. How can we conceive of space as a stage for men and not merely a somewhat nostalgic object of contemplation? A dramaturgy of landscape has to be reinvented. A scenography of landscape has to be restored with actors and not merely spectators.
Paule Virilio, *A Landscape of Events*, Cambridge, Massachusettes, 1998.

Anxiety
Landscape is something we experience with all our senses. Even from the air-conditioned interior of a moving car, we experience vistas, changing daylight, heat, wind and rain. A landscape still evokes emotions. Restricting ourselves to the visual experience, to the eyes and the brain behind them, we perceive the Netherlands as an alternation of wide, flat meadows, areas of water, towns and woodlands. This perception generally takes place in motion: observation of a static landscape has become a rare phenomenon. When major changes in a landscape are imminent, you have to take your time – whether as a connoisseur, designer, resident or proprietor – and postpone you judgement and consider things carefully. Do your ideas, knowledge and opinions correspond with what you see? An intense experience of the landscape is essential to understanding. The insight that the members of Observatorium themselves had in this respect was that spatial planning arouses emotions such as suspicion, aggression and anxiety among those not engaged in the planning. It elicits the instinct for territorial defence. Observatorium's proposal drew unexpected sympathy because it presented itself as neutral territory.

Entrance
Following their six-month stay in New York, Ruud Reutlingsperger, Andre Dekker and Geert van de Camp decided they would like to continue their collaboration in Rotterdam. They took an office and set up a foundation – and then made the acquaintance of Anne-Mie Devolder from Architecture International Rotterdam. On seeing their *Dwelling for Seclusion* in New York, she spontaneously invited them to take part in AIR Zuidwaarts/Southbound, a wide-ranging study towards new forms of urban extension and rural renewal.

AIR Zuidwaarts/Southbound invited six groups of landscape architects and urban planners to consider issues of urbanization combined with preservation of landscape quality and assets. Observatorium was added to a list of individual artists who were commissioned to carry out exploratory studies for the island of Hoeksche Waard before the landscape architects had their turn.

This marked Observatorium's initiation into the fields of spatial planning, nature management, urban development, landscape architecture and art in the public space. One thing that Observatorium was about to learn was that none of these academic disciplines can ignore the forces of tradition, politics and beliefs. Typical of the sentiments they had to deal with were: "This conference is all very well but I hope you realize these plans concern my land – you won't get very far if I refuse to sell," and, "You are just using the guise of a cultural festival to soften us up for the big city invading the countryside." Observatorium was still dizzy with the response it had received to the *Dwelling for Seclusion* in a New York park, and decided to make a variant of the bookcase house to be sited in the green polders of Hoeksche Waard.

Speaking the client's language

AIR-Zuidwaarts/Southbound sought new concepts for the selected area which would embody a synthesis between new urban functions and the historical and visual qualities of the rural landscape. Important topics which the project addressed were the international discussion on identity carriers for metropolitan regions in Europe, and the qualities the countryside can contribute to growing urban areas. The subject under consideration was the future design of the Randstad conurbation's South Wing and of the Delta (the estuaries between Rotterdam and Antwerp). The project itself, and the traditional commissions for design work, related to the island of Hoeksche Waard, to the south of Rotterdam. This island had so far somehow managed to evade the scrutiny of planners, but the pressure of urbanization was making itself increasingly felt there.

AIR-Zuidwarts/Southbound also aimed to stimulate all the sectors, authorities, corporations and interest groups involved in the spatial development of the South Wing of the Randstad with international visions on the synthesis between urbanization, traffic, agriculture, nature and recreation. The plans that emerged from this exercise were not conceived with realization in mind, but aimed rather to instigate a professional discussion through an active presentation of research and design. In the course of a year, work was to be commissioned from landscape architects, designers, artists, photographers and designers from the Netherlands and abroad.

Mechanization

Observatorium had discovered a dead end on the topographic map. On arrival at the site, they found a fence with an empty triangular piece of land behind it. This was in the middle of an empty rectangular area of asphalt, and the whole thing was surrounded by potato fields. The predominant geographical feature of rural Hoeksche Waard turned out to be a car park for maintenance workers of an underground pipeline highway. Sixteen pipelines link the refineries of the ports of Rotterdam, Moerdijk and Antwerp. The farmers rent the land above the pipelines. This is rather strong evidence for the interweaving of town with country and of nature with economics; and in this respect it is an admonition to refrain from categorizing land use.

Observatorium had free use of the site, subject to a prohibition on digging into the ground. The helicopter pilots who kept an eye on the pipeline highway had been warned. The potato farmers' crop sprayers took no notice, and the same applied to the firemen who were preoccupied with preventing flooding in this particular area in the rainy summer of 1998. Participants at one of the conferences claimed that the farmland of Hoeksche Waard differed little from an industrial park; but their remarks related only to tilling the soil, for they were unaware of what was happening below and above ground.

Exploration

The task of exploring the potential of Hoeksche Waard was something Observatorium was glad to leave to the users of the new dwelling for seclusion. Observatorium found support for this idea in classical antiquity, especially in the Latin distinction between *negotium* and *otium* – between the pragmatic lifestyle and philosophical contemplation. *Negotium* is politics, trade and the working day of the city dweller; *otium* is time when work is not required and is free of the pressures of survival. Otium, not unlike a holiday, is a time for gathering new energy and preparing for mundane social obligations.

To form an impression of the history, politics, character and nature of the district, people in all professional categories from town and country were challenged to experience isolation and leave a record of their findings. As a sample, the guest list included the mayor, a theologian, nature conservationists, architects, artists, radio producers, seekers after God, secretaries, entrepreneurs and the head of Planning in the Provincial Executive (who favoured major changes for the island, while preserving the putative quality of the landscape). Each stayed alone for a day and a night in a remote corner of a landscape of mechanized agriculture (which in the Netherlands counts as "nature") and reconsidered or even reversed their opinion on Dutch urbanization.

Solitude is a popular theme. It is reminiscent of childhood, with its moments of anxiety and loneliness, yet many wish to experience it in the hope of gaining new insights or a purification of the soul. Solitude in Hoeksche Waard was also a spectacle: people drove by in cars trying to catch a glimpse of the isolated observer, radio journalists broadcast lengthy reports, and the man from the Provincial Executive of South Holland, who was responsible for the planned transformation of the landscape, awoke in the morning to find himself surrounded by landscape preservationists and members of the press.

The distance from the inhabited world made it unnecessary to build a closed dwelling. Instead, the shelter consisted of three bookcase modules on a deck, with a kitchen and sanitary facilities plus outdoor and indoor spaces for the resident. The necessary activities of watching, sitting, washing, eating, writing and observation took place on what may be described as a raised platform with structures placed on it – a very practical arrangement, since bean, potato and cabbage plants were growing ever higher all around. The *Observatory* stood in the middle of the land area at issue. An elevation of 70 centimetres was sufficient to create a sense of distance. The bookcases, which in New York had provided visual enclosure, here offered a variety of communicative openings.

Since AIR/Southwards was about the tensions and interactions between Hoeksche Waard and the metropolitan area and harbour of Rotterdam, all the drawings, texts and photos made in Hoeksche Waard were exhibited in Rotterdam. Observatorium built a third version of the bookcase module for the purpose of this exhibition. It took the form of a reading room in the garden of Villa Alckmaer, an exhibition facility belonging to the arts centre Centrum Beeldende Kunst Rotterdam.

Observatorium was asked to present their findings at a large conference in Rotterdam where urban planners and landscape architects would first come together. Rather than speaking themselves, the Observatorium artists invited several of its guests to tell the assembled designers about their personal experiences and insights.

Observations by guests

Neighbour turns up with dog. Treads cautiously onto the decking. Was he bothering me? I was busy drawing but, never mind, I put it down. It was a funny kind of building, he thought. And he was surprised it'd been allowed. The farmers around here can't get away with a thing. It'll be rotten by winter, he said, if it didn't fall down first. Good soil here, good farming. Layer of silt, with dykes all around. He knew the names of all the dykes. The land was built up layer by layer; a new deposit of silt on top of the old one, and dykes all round. Every polder has a slope: higher on the landward side, lower towards the sea. The silt is good soil for farming, for crops and all kinds of plants. But the farmers are getting ruined by land

reorganization and low produce prices. This area ought to stay green and used for farming. It's a landscape you have to know.
Marcel Dekker

Physical orientation: traverse the whole courtyard. The yard seems important; it forms a unity with the interior, because it increases the sense of space as regards personal space as opposed to natural space. The feeling is wholly unlike that of a summer house. The binomial of inside/outside is doubly applicable: cella/yard and yard/domain. The dome of the sky, which is limitlessly observable, gives the main feeling. The land and its contents vanish in comparison. The value of this landscape lies in the huge sense of space that comes from the immense, ever-changing sky. Room has to be left for that experience, literally and figuratively.
Rob de Carpentier, 11 September 1998

Spending a day living in the Observatory gives an entirely different dimension to the way you experience it. The structures do radiate a kind of mysterious quietness, certainly, but by living them they quickly turn into your own home town.

The forms, which are based on the ideas of Dom Hans van der Laan, are so restful. They strike me as a cross between the architecture of Palladio and the sculptures of Donald Judd – Palladio on account of their symmetry and dimensioning, Judd because of the box-like repetitions, and both of these because of the simple austerity that is their hallmark. Yet the image of Joseph Beuys that predominates, rather than that of say De Stijl, Sol LeWitt or Donald Judd. That is in my view not so much because of the use of felt, a typical Beuys material, but primarily because of the *Observatory* itself. The project so intimately involves the spectator through his or her participation, that Beuys's standpoint, that sculpture is important only insofar it contributes to the development of human consciousness, is realized almost implicitly.

That the bookcase structure, with all those straight segments, accords with the kind of apartment design that is so typical of contemporary urban development, may well be my personal response, but it is an aspect that combines with the form and the volume of this Observatory (a deck with three buildings) to make it today into my most cherished city.
Etienne Dupoint, 31 August 1998

Temporarily shifted some lumps of clay. They'll have to be put back when I go. Putting brown bean plants on clay plinths. Seems to me that this is a fine place to say where the brown beans that you often see in my work come from.

I was twenty when I came to live in Hoeksche Waard. First I lived temporarily in an old farmhand's cottage on Middelsluissedijk in Numansdorp. An retired farm worker had his vegetable garden there. He was called Toon Havelaar and must have been about 70. He was a tall, fine-looking man – and strong too. Once he came walking along the dyke with his grandson over his shoulder. Bolt upright. Lovely thing to see, that was. He hardly gave me a glance, or so it seemed. Then one day he came over to me and showed me something. "Lovely, aren't they", was all he said. In his hand there were three brown beans, gleaming like jewels. I was overwhelmed with surprise, and I still am.
Hanneke Piederiet, 24 September 1998

[drawing by Arie Verhij]

The past is the past and us susceptible only to analysis. The present is a continually moving boundary between the past and the future. The future is a zone of planning and projection.

That is what makes the future so treacherous; no experience from the past can guarantee the future, however much effort we make to refine it in the present. This too is what is so worrying about

the plans we have for the landscape. Plans, whether the work of nature lovers, economists, agriculturalists or anyone else, are active interventions in the course of events. A plan involves risks. Today, my feeling is that as regards landscape and other aspects of nature, we ought to take a conservative stance much more often than we do.

The birds I saw yesterday are there again, giving me a feeling of safety and familiarity. I can well imagine that St. Francis went to talk to the animals. Their only wish, it seems, is to be themselves, in this place and in this manner.

The bookcases in the Observatory symbolize to me the empty space around me. In the same way as I sense an irresistible urge in myself to start filling their shelves, the planners must have an unrelenting desire to fill up the empty polders of the island. Empty space is nothing; emptiness insists on being filled up. But who interprets the emptiness as nothing? Space of itself lacks any package of demands. The filling of space is functional thinking.

The village to which I shall soon return has remained the same. I have changed; changed in the way that I have been changed through my walks through nature and through my pilgrimage to Santiago de Compostela. It is not a spectacular change of outlook, but a deepening of feelings, and a wider perspective on the panting importance of it all. My temporary presence is considerably less important to my surroundings than I am usually inclined to think.

Following my stay here, will I fight harder for the preservation of Hoeksche Waard in its present state? No, I will feel briefly convinced of the necessity, of the beauty, but at the same time the sense of perspective is greater. Change will come, and what remains will be mere trimmings of the economic blanket that will spread over Hoeksche Waard. But there is more hope.
Huub van der Hoogenhoff, 5 August 1998

Entering the Observatory
Twenty or thirty metres before I reached the Observatory, I paused. Only now did it strike me with how much consideration all that woodwork had been inserted into the landscape. A wooden deck of roughly ten metres square floated like a little public plaza one metre above the landscape. On it were three small volumes, one with an open, veranda like structure and the other two like closed cubicles. It looked like an instant temple – something that in my imagination could easily be extended to become a whole fleet of decks. Was it perhaps the draft design of a model home for future residents of Hoeksche Waard? It formed a counterpoint with the farmette-style neighbourhoods I had seen in the polders on the way here. Might this not be the start of an entirely new concept for village extensions? At the same time, it had the air of something very old that had long stood here without pretensions to being anything else. Yet it clearly seemed to be awaiting something. What? Who? I resumed the path leading up to the Observatory. I heard the buzz of a propellor. Roaring over the potato fields, a plane was trailing a long, wide curtain of insecticide behind it, interrupting the mist briefly as it passed deafeningly overhead. Then, zigzagging back and forth across the farmland landscape, it continued its business of annihilating the local insect population. I was surrounded by a total landscape; an osmosis of mists and vapours over the marine clay.

As I approached the Observatory, I was careful because of the swallows who had claimed my attention; that is, not so much the birds themselves as the way they were swooping around the Observatory. It reminded me of my introduction to the island of Tiengemeten on the other side. The farmers there had to leave their farms because the land was soon to be flooded. I had seen swallows drawing similar patterns in the air around the abandoned farmhouses. With the fate of Hoeksche Waard in my mind, I stepped up onto the deck. How could I interpret it all?

Tiengemeten, a historically important cultivated landscape, was being allowed to slide back under the water from which it had once been extracted, under the banner of nature development. It seemed more like a ritual sacrifice to me – a sacrifice of an history unequalled in the polders to the water, a sacrifice to progress. Unlike Tiengemeten, Hoeksche Waard is to be developed further for

human use. An extension of the Rotterdam harbour is planned in this direction, and new housing estates have been proposed here; after all, people have to live somewhere. Meanwhile, I was getting a pricking feeling in my eyes. I wondered how the swallows were managing. Apparently they must have built up quite some resistance to the spraying, but it can't have been very pleasant for these lovely, indefatigable creatures. How could I profess my love to these new neighbours?
Martin van den Oever, 30 July 1998

During my stay, I was struck by several architectural aspects of the Observatory: the harmony of the architecture with the landscape and the changing light, both day and night. In certain situations the light can elicit a new spacial awareness; the exposition of the Other – seeing and being seen, philosophizing; inner processes – personal fears, memories and life attitudes; considerations of a social nature – fear as a fundamental, archaic fact, the woman who is constantly confronted with her vulnerability, development of the landscape culture and the surroundings caused by the changes in social structures; change of concentration due to the quiddity of nature.

Were these aspects of the Observatory part of the plan? Or does the Observatory address a more specific point of departure, one which I have perhaps failed to notice? If that is the case, how can Geert van de Camp, Andre Dekker and Ruud Reutelingsberger realize this in a more efficient way? This is also applicable if the goal of the concept comprises an experience of all layers of the above mentioned impressions.

These questions all lead to this question in particular: the question of recording the interaction between the work of art and the temporary resident. The creators have distanced themselves from the art object, as is usual in art. How do they look through with their pupils? Is that necessary or not?
Annelie David, 4 July 1998

Chapter 3

Linking Separate Worlds
Rotterdam, 2001
Nieuw Terbregge Observatory, A20, Rotterdam
Manna, A Monument to the Food Drops of the Second World War

Linking Separate Worlds
Observatorium takes a stand against the fragmentation of the world into separate zones for working, leisure, transport, shopping, housing, nature and waste. Observatorium rejects the boundaries between the separate worlds, and uses them to make connections.

[quotes]
A Sense of Place, a Sense of Time
John Brinckerhoff Jacksen, New Haven, 1994

Artists come and go, and "infect" the participants for the duration of the intervention. ... The long-term effect their actions is unknown, for it is never measured.
From Q.S. Serafijn, *Aantekeningen/Notes*, The Hague, 1999

Commission
A bursary enabled Observatorium to realize *Dwellings for Seclusion* in Berlin, New York, Rotterdam, Düsseldorf and Hoeksche Waard. Then the first paid commission turned up . Manja Ellenbroek, from the Rotterdam property development company Proper-Stok, had been as fervent an attendant at the three-day congress on entanglements and conflicts between town and country as the artists of Observatorium. It was in effect a crash course in urban planning – on how the redistribution of space becomes condensed into plans and policies, and on how the present users of that space resist the proposed changes. The pressure for change often comes from an abstract source (the Port of Rotterdam) but the defence is often highly personal (a particular farmer).

Amid speeches on the day to day reality of farming, on nature conservation, political dilemmas and secret wishes, the philosophical commentaries and the tears of the author Paul Shepheard introduced some confusion and fresh air. Shepheard, Ellenbroek and Reutlingsperger became acquainted during corridor chats, and challenged one another to a form of collaboration.

A Sculpture for a new housing estate
Proper-Stok, the company responsible for the development of a new housing estate of about 850 homes, commissioned Observatorium to provide a sculpture which would be a gift to the City of Rotterdam and the new residents, to mark completion of the development. A hallmark of the new estate, Nieuw Terbregge, is its isolated situation in a depression between the dyke of the small River Rotte and a noise bund alongside the A20 motorway. The ideas behind the sculpture, and its form and siting, were left to the artists to decide.

Observatorium's first visit to the site finished on the noise bund, between the densely built, varied housing of the project and the wide, noisy open space of the motorway. The A20 is a notorious bottleneck in the Rotterdam orbital road system, endlessly jammed with traffic queues (if the radio is to be believed) although in this instance it made an impression of superbly organized linear mobility. It was striking that all the urban features lay parallel to the motorway: the city park, the railway, the noise bund, residential streets and the River Rotte, with the tower flats of Ommoord in the background. Here it was possible to observe the spatial structure and the conjunction of realms that are spatially separate but which city dwellers all use at some time or another. This spot, on top of the noise bund, was the right

place for the sculpture. At the boundary between stillness and motion, it was possible to oversee the separate worlds. Here, alone, you can see where you are.

Linking separate worlds

The reason the sound bund takes the form of a huge embankment measuring 2 kilometres long, 60 metres wide and 12 metres high is not because it needs to be so big to protect the adjoining areas from noise. It is because the land for the new housing estate had been used to store polluted soil which was dredged up from the Rotterdam harbour. The size of the bund was dictated by the economics of soil storage; and the size of the housing estate was dictated by the size of the bund. A mere thirty years ago, this had been a district of farmland and meadows. And just over sixty-five [~~50~~] years ago, at the end of the Second World War, this had been the locality outside the city where allied planes dropped food parcels for the inhabitants of Rotterdam. This seemingly historyless place actually lay at the intersection of two diachronically distinct worlds. This should surely be reflected in Observatorium's sculpture, but how can an artist turn sculpture (which, after all, occupies space) into a pure act of revealing? How can the work of art show what is there without devouring too much attention in its own right?

Literally and figuratively

An enclosed garden is a building. From this building, it must be possible to look into the separate worlds, and they must in some or other way meet here. What if we were to stretch both the housing estate and the motorway up onto the sound bund, in an over-literal attempt at linking the two worlds? It could result in nonsense, or it could result in humour, but in this case it resulted in a sculpture: a house on the bund with a closed garden paved with asphalt. Elaborating on this simple concept engendered further ideas. If there is one enclosed garden on the dyke, and it has to be visible from two sides, then it must have a difference in vertical relief and will be partitioned into a quiet part and a noise-exposed part. If the garden is lower than the top of the bund, it creates the suggestion that landfill material lies under the grass over the whole bund. If the house projects out towards the motorway, then it results in a scaffold sticking out of the embankment, from which one can see passing motorists through their windscreens.

A hybrid abstraction of a house, garden, window, staircase and scaffold, bounded on all sides by the disparate realities of the motorway, housing estate and landfill tip, gradually developed. The game of meaning and form led ultimately to a sculpture with two faces: the mysterious, projecting fragment of a building which betrays the existence of life behind the bund, and the Zen-like stone garden with a view of the pulsating world of transport and speed. The bright idea of building all this from crash barriers imparted unity to the whole; the seams between the components provided transparency. For outsiders, it appeared as a hybrid in a different sense: was it landscape architecture, was it architecture, was it sculpture – or was it just unfinished?

Enclosed garden

Observatorium received the book *The Enclosed Garden* by Rob Aben and Saskia de Wit (010 Publishers, 1998) as a gift, and found a drawing of the motorway, sound bund and meadows of Terbregge on page 242. There was no sign of a housing estate in the book, but an "observatory" was mentioned. The authors had pictured a contemporary version of the walled garden for the benefit of passing motorists. An opening and a gateway in the embankment would offer a momentary glimpse of the enclosed garden of Terbregge. At the time of writing, the authors did not know that houses would be built there, and they had not yet heard of the Observatorium group.

The Enclosed Garden describes countless variations on the paradoxical human need to appropriate territory from the world and then admit the world into it. We can invite the earth and nature to enter into the enclosure of a garden that forms part of our habitation. Observatorium had already incorporated this paradox into their design: an enclosed garden alongside the motorway could

be both a sculpture, the tangible object that had been commissioned, and a means of condensing the bizarre combination of disparate worlds.

Cultural capital

If a work by Observatorium remains unused, then it is unfinished. The *Dwellings for Seclusion*, in the period from 1994 to 1998, were in fact sculptures with a living, human component. The Nieuw Terbrugge Observatory was similarly intended to be used and visited as much as possible. Since it was eventually to be a gift to the housing estate, it seemed only logical to make it suitable for many forms of use.

An electricity supply was connected, and the pavilion was made big enough to accommodate various functions for periods of various lengths. On delivery of the first section of the housing estate, the development company and the Rotterdam Planning and Housing Department decided to use the pavilion for an exhibition about the building of the housing estate and the sustainability measures taken there. Motorway materials formed part of the exhibition design: signage light boxes displayed photoreportages on topics such as heliophyte filtration and solar boilers. The exhibition was an apt contribution to the Woonstad (Residential City) component of Rotterdam Cultural Capital of Europe. Nieuw Terbrugge Observatory attracted thousands of visitors in its first few months of its existence.

It quickly became a familiar part of the scene. In contrast to the pleasantly smooth progress of constructing the work, an early baptism of fire as regards art in the public space awaited Observatorium shortly afterwards. Although the pavilion was spared the commonplace insult of graffiti, the photographs and light boxes were mercilessly trashed. Feeling a little morose, the artists began a quest for whoever would be next to use the pavilion for their own purposes. Who would be prepared to offer this brand new but already soiled premises a further lease of life?

Monument

The Observatorium artists were not the only people to have paced the streets of Nieuw Terbregge with an emotional agenda. In the closing months of the war in 1945, Henk Dijkxshoorn had watched as the Allied Lancaster bombers dropped food parcels for the hungry inhabitants of Rotterdam in Operation Manna and Operation ChowHound. In his view, the *Observatory* on the sound bund looked out not onto the motorway but onto the hallowed ground where that astonishing event had taken place. He asked Observatorium to help him establish a memorial to the food drops, and they responded by offering him space and a design on the condition that the memorial monument would be situated on the sound bund.

The heavy bombers skimming low over the meadows, laden with food parcels, was an image that appealed to everyone's imagination. The monument represents the food parcels stowed into the belly of a plane. A plaque in the middle of the asphalt garden records the historical event, so the local primary schoolchildren are not likely to forget it.

The sculpture was unveiled in 2006 in the presence of the State Secretary for the Interior, the Mayor and numerous diplomats. A memorial ceremony for the servicemen took place in 2007, and the path leading to the garden on the sound bund was renamed Geddespad, in honour of Major Geddes who organized the food drops in the Netherlands.

The Public Side of the Private - and Vice Versa (Rotterdam, A20)

Christian Welzbacher, 2001

It is doubtful whether there is even such a thing as private space in The Netherlands. Except for a few areas in the province of Friesland in the northeast, where farmers live in the midst of their extensive tracts of land, about 16 million people live right next to each other on man-made land won from the sea.

Both the industrialised cultivation and the density of development that have still not solved the housing problem have been the themes of architecture and landscape architecture in The Netherlands for some time. What the MVRDV office showed at the World's Fair in Hannover with its artificial sandwich garden is only one of many possible images of the environment that determines what the people in The Netherlands are like. There is no such thing as privacy, even though the Calvinist way of life exposed to view without any curtains is often draped by now and many residents seek at least visual protection from their neighbours.

Nieuw Terbregge, in the northeast of the Rotterdam conurbation, is no exception. The property was long one of the dumps of urban architecture, a derelict leftover space between the motorway and the little River Rotte flowing five metres higher up. Now that a large part of the total of 850 standard single-family homes is completed, the dominating element is the series. Not two or five but dozens of identical houses appear in a row. The principle of chronic repetition evokes another image in turn: that of a society of people who are all the same, even if only to the architects responsible for the design. Even the idyll of outdoor space between the houses is planned: narrow stairs lead across the newly built canals; parking spots are hidden under wooden beams and metal rods that are meant to be overgrown soon. The interwoven aspect of Dutch cultivation is thus simulated in the heart of the development in a purposive optimistic manner. If this had not been the case, the community would have corrected this distortion in favour of something like private or free or open space. One would almost expect that horror vacui would automatically set in amongst the residents.

The test tube village just doesn't want to have anything to do with the outside world. The grounds are about six metres below sea level and separated from the motorway by an eleven-metre-high noise barrier embankment made of contaminated rubble. It reduces the traffic noises to a dull minimum. Only the sparkling silvery pavilion that the Rotterdam Observatorium group of artists set up on the summit of the embankment breaks up the illusion. The structure shifts the perception of both residents and drivers. It becomes a visual centre of attraction for both, and it abolishes the boundaries between the traffic-restricted centrifugal world behind the hill and the turbo-dynamic linear world in front of it.

The enclosed garden with a view, on the borderline between architecture, art and landscape design, that the group of artists and architects working together since 1995 was able to realise here on the invitation of the developer, consists of three parts. Arising like the ruins of a medieval fortress is a medium-high tower with an adjacent small shelter that is also used for temporary exhibitions. The successes of duurzaam, sustainable building, whose fundamentals were worked out in Brussels and determined the housing development, were presented on backlit panels in this part of the pavilion made of guard-rails in 2001. The horizontal counterpart to the tower is a sweeping ramp. It leads straight out towards the motorway from the summit of the hill, which is levelled to look like an adjacent square. Right next to it, hugging the steeply sloping terrain, is the third part of the ensemble that also serves to frame it: a rectangular hortus conclusus made of layers of asphalt slabs framed by stone gabion walls.

In a bizarre way the monument-like pavilion and its small rough front garden on either side of the summit of the embankment reflect a long-forgotten Dutch dream of dreams: a single-family home at a distance to the neighbours, a solitaire in the landscape. However, the Observatorium reverses this wishful thinking of privacy: the pavilion is open, accessible to everyone. It is not an isolated home but an architectural sculpture that seeks contact with the world around it. The structure confronts unsuspecting residents behind the noise barrier visually with the spoils of the motorway that they would rather be spared, though they use it to get to town every day nevertheless. The pavilion is spotlighted until late at night, inviting people to admire its guard-rail construction, to saunter along the ramp, and to watch the cars rushing by or the notorious traffic jams. Thus its creates a link between here and there, providing every happy homeowner in cosy Nieuw Terbregge the opportunity for a brief recovery from the loss of reality at night.

Through its materials the ensemble also uses the setting as its theme, concentrating the building materials of the embankment and the motorway into a work of its own. The theme is therefore not the urbanisation of the landscape as such but the particular artificiality of a certain unique place in a completely reshaped landscape. Works by the Observatorium group first expose the essence of the context, reduce it to its essentials and finally re-assemble it. In this way the structure bridges the gap between the disparate opposites that have long become interconnections in the densely settled Netherlands. In a peaceful state of balance, like a temple in a landscape garden, the Observatory radiates outwards into its surroundings and declares everything around it part of a large park: the noise barrier, the new development, the motorway, the historical course of the Rotte, the Terbregseplein motorway junction, and the grand view in the shape of the Rotterdam skyline. And just like in the pavilions in old pictures of the Garden of Paradise, everything comes to a standstill inside this building too. The folly of Nieuw Terbregge thus becomes a public place that invites private retreat. Making such self-generated paradoxes visible and enjoyable in other parts of the country as well, heightening them without aiming to change them, characterises the work of the Observatorium group.

Chapter 4

Civilization is Maintenance
Hoogezand, 2003
Otium Leinewijk, Hoogezand
Part of the Semslinie Art Route

Civilization is Maintenance
Observatorium makes works of art that are "unfinished" and which develop in time. Civilization is similarly not a snapshot in time but a process. Maintenance is part of that development, not of the status quo.

[quote]
The space of nature has three characteristics that put it beyond our grasp. It is unbounded, it is without shape and it is unmeasurable. Architecture is simply that which must be added to that space to make it inhabitable, visible and measurable. Inhabitable here means bounded in relation to the human body, visible means bounded in relation to our senses and measurable means bounded in relation to our intellect.

Dom Hans van der Laan, *De Architectonische Ruimte*, Leiden 1977.

Semslinie
The Dutch government reserves one percent of every public building budget for art. This applies not only to actual buildings but also to landscape redevelopment. The Semslinie Art Route comprises nine works of art commissioned to commemorate a major transformation of the landscape, involving the merging of farms, the redistribution of ditches and fields and improvements in road infrastructure in the former peat-extraction "colonies" of Groningen and Drente. It is an ambitious project intended to help boost the economy of a relatively neglected area. The farms will be larger but there will also be more room for recreation and nature. The goal of the art project was to draw attention to the quality and character of the landscape. The curator, the artist Loes Heebink, took the Semslinie, a 400 year old feature running in a perfectly straight line through the landscape for about 40 kilometers, as the basis. As she stated, "The works of art must not only enter into a dialogue with its specific surroundings, but they must establish a connection between the present, past and future."

The location assigned to Observatorium was in the middle of a large area of treeless potato fields, backed onto by surrounding farms along the horizon. The peat districts of the Netherlands are associated with economic hardship and empty, disconsolate, unappealing countryside. It was Observatorium's first visit to this kind of region. The dwellings for seclusion in New York and Hoeksche Waard were child's play in comparison to the pioneering work that would be needed in the Peat District.

Starting over
Wherever you stand, you have to picture a layer of peat reaching well above your head, to imagine what the original landscape must have been like. You stand on the sandy bed of what was once an immense black sponge measuring some 40 x 70 kilometres – peat that has been extracted, transported and burnt as fuel.

Once the peat had been extracted, the inhabitants had to make a new start somewhere else. Topographical maps from the 19th century, from 1950 and from 1990 show that the immediate surroundings of the Leinewijk Canal have been thoroughly dug over no less than three times in the hundred years since the first colonization. Each time, the farms, the fields and the roads grew larger, and the population and the number of trees shrank. Various economic crises, major and minor, took place in

the meanwhile. The future does not look much different; another round of digging up, reconstruction and settlement is in prospect. Where potato fields now lie to the north of the Leinewijk Canal, a new extension is planned for Hoogezand, a town which to an outsider seems to consist solely of new extensions. Starting again, reconstruction and settlement indicate optimism, but when it happens that often it all has an air of desperation.

Remote

The location and its history obliged Observatorium to act as pioneers. Another artist may read something in history that inspires him to do something with a laser beam, an archway or a machine, but, for Observatorium, designing and constructing a work of art is tantamount to settling in a place. What symbolic gesture could hold its own on this windswept plain? Who would monitor this emptiness against the predations of vandalism? This is no community or habitation here waiting with open arms to embrace a work of art. The elements are so overwhelming here that only a work portraying the struggle against the elements would suffice. Then it would be no more than logical that someone would settle here: the pioneering spirit *is* the sculpture. The work must form part of the perpetual cycle of this terrain's history, of its exploitation, settlement and resettlement. Following the two previous temporary dwellings for solitude, this work would have to endure the test of time.

Requirements

Art is free but a dwelling must meet a list of requirements. Observatorium drew up its own programme. The landscape here is subject to continual change and the dwelling must change along with it. The location is on the edge of the peat district so the sculpture had to be a gateway to that landscape.

Recreation is considered ever more important, so passing tourists must be able to stop here and take in the view. The district is given over to small-scale industry and large-scale arable farming, so more space for creativity, relaxation and hospitality would be welcome here.

Works of art in the public space belong to and are addressed to everyone. The community decorates its public space with art for the sake of beauty, memory, atmosphere or the need for a focus of spatial organization. The public space, by belonging to one and all, has as many characters as there are human characters. Although both the space and the work of art belong to one and all, "democratic" homogenization is not a valuable contribution to the design of public space. There are many alternatives. For Observatorium's first commission for a work of art in the public space, the artists decided on the opposite: the work would not be dedicated to one and all, but to a single individual.

Location

The location consists of two verges alongside the bicycle path and a strip of greenery at the foot of the canal dyke. It took a while to find out who owned the land: the dyke belonged to the Water Boards and the verges to the municipality. A change to the zoning plan was need to enable construction. The dwelling was classified in the building category "non-building". In less organized landscapes, you sometimes can't be sure if a path has reached a dead-end or if it enters private property. May you continue or not? The distinction between public and private is not particularly clear: they are ostensible opposites but one cannot exist without the other. By building on both sides of the path, Observatorium created a fusion of the public and private. *Otium* would not be an enclave, but the landscape would be enriched by a piece of land of an unusual intermediate status. By straddling the route, the work would act as a gateway to the landscape.

The modular, disassemblable construction of the dwelling made it future-ready – a future that, some six years after completion, was clearly approaching with ominous speed, when it appeared that a planned extension to the town of Hoogezand was to swallow up the *Otium*. Could it survive? All its elements rest on foundation pads and both the steel and wooden components are detachable.

Otium was built in using the proportional system of Dom van der Laan. The basic plate, bar and block forms of his Abacus appear here in the dwelling, the railing and the tower. The components were arranged to form a kind of yard that incorporates the public bicycle path. The idea was to tempt the passing cyclist to slow down or take a break.

Use versus symbolism

The physical structure was modular and suitable for varying uses, but a similarly flexible legal structure was also necessary. Observatorium established a foundation called Stichting Otium Leinewijk, appointed a board, and handed the whole thing over the to first owner/manager, the Groningen journalist Linda Schregardus. The statutes state that the manager must take responsibility for management and maintenance, as well as for sharing the *Otium* with others. She herself added carved lines of verse, and a well, to the *Otium*. The task of management and the opportunity to work further on the *Otium* were transferred after five years to Mijnske Sival. She specialized in setting up educational projects for young people from the surrounding area, and added an orchard. These are small signs of civilization in a desolate spot, which ensure that at least someone will maintain the public work of art, as a counter to the attraction it could exert on vandals.

The colour of the concrete and the height of the rooms relate to the layer of turf that once covered this expanse of land. The modular system of steel and wooden components echoes the grid patterns of the landscape. Nonetheless, *Otium Leinewijk* has become a strange kind of place. People who stay there can lock the door but cannot withdraw entirely from the outside world; there is no fence around the land. Its isolation, particularly, arouses the curiosity of passers-by. The passing cyclists feel free to dismount and enter the residence, although they usually ask permission anyway. The lack of a clear boundary brings the passer-by and the user into conversation. It is this encounter that defines the border.

Otium Leinewijk

Paul Mezie, 2004

It's a critical question in our interdisciplinary era: at what point does public sculpture become architecture? Observatorium is a Rotterdam-based artists' collective that explores the fuzzy boundaries at the frontiers of art and architecture. Its three members – Geert van de Camp, Andre Dekker and Ruud Reutelingsperger, none of whom trained as an architect – have been addressing the fundamental issues of architecture, landscape and land use in their built works since the mid 1990s. Observatorium is notable for its interdisciplinary transgressions, but at the same time its activities are, in many ways, like those of countless other contemporary designers and artists. As a group, they have been working diligently and without fanfare, in a thoughtful and philosophical way, propelled by various kinds of funding, commissions and public exposure.

It seems appropriate to describe Observatorium's aspirations by quoting Samuel Beckett's Molloy: "To restore silence is the role of objects." Typically, their works are conceived as pavilion-scale viewing devices or observatories. Most are interactive, in that they can be inhabited by the viewer for varying durations – from minutes to as long as a day. The small buildings create tangible frames of reference and viewpoints that seem to slow time. Through observation, sustained attention, contemplation and meditation, the user can gain new perspectives on the external environment, as well as the inner self.

The members of Observatorium started their collaboration with a series of distinct built works, each named an *Observatory*, in the Netherlands and Germany. In 1997, they made their North American debut at Snug Harbor Cultural Center in New York with another Observatory, which was also known as the Dwelling for Seclusion. In 2001, an international jury of architects awarded the project a Bauwelt Prize, an annual award sponsored by the German architecture magazine of the same name. This pavilion,

placed in a public park, operated as a 24-hour retreat and guesthouse in which all the guests' needs were met, the artists even catering a home-cooked meal. As an investigation into the essence of human habitation, the space was outfitted with only the necessities for minimal physical comfort, plus some texts, paintings and sculptures, also by the artists, for intellectual study.

The observatories are intended to encourage an individual subjective experience of otium, the Latin word for dignified leisure and ease. Observatorium also invites other forms of individual involvement in its public work, which questions the interrelation of public and private and confounds our expectations of public art's traditionally generic programs and permanence. At Otium Leinewijk the collective considers the structure incomplete and invites additions by other people. Through what can only be described as acts of civic generosity by the artists, the pavilions often come with surprising and complex operational relationships, stewardship schemes and ownership structures that ultimately contribute to the actual ongoing success of the projects as public art. Otium Leinewijk is a publicly funded artwork on public lands, but it has been given on permanent loan to a local private citizen who is invested in the project's ambitions. She manages, maintains and reconfigures the structures, as the opportunity or need arises, and also ensures public access to them at no cost and without limitations.

The identity of each Observatory is, in large part, derived from the particular landscape or site on which it is built. The individual observatories heighten the sense of place and compel an awareness of the surroundings. From the vantage point of the pavilions, one can see more clearly the effects of human artifice on the environment. Visitors are presented with scenes that contain the same intellectual and aesthetic promise as a landscape photograph or painting. In the case of the Nieuw Terbregge Observatory, built at the crest of a monumental man-made earthwork dike at Rotterdam's northern outskirts, the pavilion is structured as a lookout over two distinct and separate built environments. In one direction, the lookout is immediately above the A20 freeway, which links the main cities of the Dutch Randstad; Rotterdam's growing skyline is visible on the horizon beyond. In the other direction, the view is over a polder, a quintessential below-sea-level Dutch landscape, which in this case has been transformed into a new canal-based housing development (see Azure Sept/Oct 2002, Mecanoo).

Otium Leinewijk, near Groningen, intensifies the experience and understanding of the local typically Dutch agricultural countryside and geomorphological history. This pavilion, situated on a small dike next to a canal, is accessible only by bike or on foot. Here, visitors can meditate on both the obvious and invisible conditions of environmental reconstruction in the landscape. Built to the exact height of the original peat bog, which was removed to create arable land, the steel and wood structure is infilled with red concrete walls that refer to the colour of the lost peat.

Observatorium's projects in the open landscape always act as indexes of the place, but in a recent work it is the prospective users who are most significantly represented in the design. The new courtyard landscape for the De Leij in Vught juvenile prison was created through a dialogue with the inmates, whose ideas have faithfully become a part of the work, reflecting their individual voices and desires. A tropical greenhouse, replete with palm tree and sand beach, a car-repair compound, and an allotment garden are all parts of the project.

In Observatorium's work, beautiful structures, spaces and settings are presented as both a public right and a privilege, and definitely not as a luxury or as mere beautification. Projects are in equal measure programmatic, didactic and aesthetic. Following in the traditions of art practice, they are crafted carefully and built by the artists themselves. In each of the projects, the artists have formally experimented with materials and construction methods that are, metaphorically or literally, site-specific, such as the cleft and stacked recycled asphalt paving at Nieuw Terbregge. By building places for human dwelling, Observatorium succeeds in enhancing our understanding of the world around us and ultimately ourselves.

In Search of the Lost Reality

Louise Schouwenberg, 2002

Building a hut, claiming your own territory – it's a game every child has played, isn't it? Who cannot recall the sheer delight of building an improvised structure, balanced, perhaps precariously, in the branches of a sturdy tree? A simpler version is almost as good: throw a few old sheets over the steps, a few chairs or the kitchen table and you have created your own little dominion. Amid the hustle and bustle of the household, you are shielded from the prying eyes of parents and older siblings, while their chattering voices soften to a murmur. In the dim light and quiet of your private realm, your imagination can run free. There are still a few gaps and holes that let you keep an eye on the outside world; separation from the family scene is not quite total. Maybe this delicious paradox is why many people never stop building things. They make a profession of devising ingenious structures that serve as houses or public buildings, but which often remain foreign bodies in relation to their surroundings. Rarely, however, do they succeed in recreating the tension between an interior and exterior world that we remember from those childhood games.

It is striking how many resemblances there are between the secluded domain under the kitchen table and the dwellings built since 1993 by the artists Andre Dekker, Geert van de Camp and Ruud Reutelingsperger, working under the collective name of Observatorium. The latter label also applies to the structures they have built: an *Observatory* is a secluded situation that allows tranquillity and reflection for its occupant, while serving as a lookout on the encompassing town or country and its activities. Sovereign and inward-looking, these structures turn their backs on the outside world but seem nonetheless to blend well into those surroundings.

Seclusion in the public space: what is it that motivates these artists? Are they forever recreating a childish dream? Do they seek the lost days of childhood or are they pursuing something beyond that? To my question about Observatorium's follies, Van de Camp responded as follows. "They are certainly not just harking back to childhood. Our buildings are meant to be used. In essence, every person wishes to create a personal space from which they can venture out into the world. We repeat that process over and again, and then donate an empty shell to those users who turn up." Reutelinsperger adds that the buildings are in no way meant as a form of self-expression. "We do not present a fully finished work of art, but just possibilities and conditions. It is not our own wishes but those of the users that eventually complete the work of art. We just offer them the bare framework, you could say."

"The kind of usability we aim for is primarily a mental one," Dekker says. "We offer the user time and space for attention and reflection, and for an enhanced private experience within the public space. Our design is almost a religious space, a general package of possibilities that the individual occupant can appropriate for his or her own purposes."

They are three independent-thinking, individualistic artists who have specialized in usable built structures. Some ten years ago, they discovered almost by chance that they shared a dislike of the countless artistic fabrications that can only thrive within the museum or gallery walls of an introspective art world. They decided to collaborate on producing work that they hoped would have more impact in the "normal" world, and show greater engagement with it. Reutelingsperger says, "You could regard us as creative problem solvers. We do not make sculpture but a grid for a better environment. The public space is packed full, as though everyone had developed a massive agoraphobia. Every millimetre is occupied by a personal domain, a little world that stands apart from the world next to it. On top of that, people add works of art which tend to impose themselves noisily on their surroundings. Things are being forever superimposed, stacked up and expanded. What we want is to do something different."

"To be precise," Dekker says, "we add nothing new but just bring things together. We open up access, so to speak, to the surrounding landscape by creating meaning-rich spaces with resources that we find in the locality. Sometimes that is the physical material, such as the fragments of asphalt and crash barrier steel we used on the sound bund. Sometimes we seek instead formal relationships between the structure and the context, such as in the case of *Otium Leinekwijk*, where the changing

peatland landscape is counterpointed by the changeable building. We must add the buildings to what is already there; at the same time, the location must call for a sculpture."

The presumed needs of the user were also foremost in the art project that Observatorium realized in the Judicial Juvenile Institution in Vught. Together with the young inmates, Observatorium built brickwork replicas of the foundations of the whole institution. These colourful foundation walls provided a basis for the next stage: the residents of this youth prison were allowed to build their own huts and alter, demolish or rebuild them however they wished. The Observatorium artists kept their involvement fairly light, but gave the youngsters a pointer, by making two structures of their own. The project was incorporated from the outset into the regular educational programme of the institution, thereby more or less ensuring continuation. A guarantee was hardly necessary, however, since the inmates worked with great enthusiasm on building a shell to contain their individual creations. The need was clearly a considerable one.

A question that inevitably arises is why Observatorium operates mainly within the sphere of fine art, rather than that of architecture or urban design. "We don't exclude that possibility," Van de Camp explains, "but we are really not like architects. We are not obliged to stick to the strict legal constraints and building regulations that limit architects and town planners in their creative freedom. Besides, the architect disappears from view almost immediately once the building is completed, while for us that is exactly where the adventure begins. Changes that take place are documented by photographs, and the experiences and observations of the users are recorded diligently by means of questionnaires. All these aspects are integral to our projects."

The semi-functional buildings of Observatorium poise somewhere in the continuum bounded by architecture, landscape architecture, formal design and fine art. Seclusion in public space; reflection amid the bustle of everyday traffic; standing still as a basis for observing the mobile world: what do these motifs amount to? The world has changed radically in recent decades. Not only is our public space stuffed full of smaller domains, functional objects and clutter, but our perception of reality has changed too. As always, we see and we are seen, we are both the subject and object of the gaze of others. But seeing and being seen hardly ever takes place directly nowadays. Through the intermediaries of TV images and the virtual worlds of the internet, we observe an image of reality that we know has been manipulated. We are moreover continually monitored, controlled and scrutinized by surveillance cameras and CCTV systems. Here too perceptions are shaped or at least influenced by intermediaries. All this mediation has made reality hypervisible and hypertransparent. But it is dubious whether this gives us a clearer view of it. Just consider the exhaustively documented wars that we can follow in the media; quite often, it turns out in retrospect that the truth was different from that portrayed. And, of course, a word like intimacy loses all its meaning once it is dished up for a mass audience through TV reality shows like Jerry Springer or Big Brother.

The media externalize our interior and make our consciousness ecstatic and excessive. Hypervisibilty creates illusions of reality, and the space between looking and being looked at is no longer dominated by the silence of the ineffable, the power of the invisible. The philosopher Baudrillard writes of an implosion of meaning; only the surface still counts. In a disenchanted world without secrets or distance, where illusion overwhelms reality, reality is itself at risk of vanishing.

A painting by Antonello da Messina (*San Gerolamo nello Studio*, c. 1460) shows a monk apparently sunk in deep in the solitude of his library, while the whole scene is open to everyone's view. Undisturbed and undisturbable by the mundane environment, the monk dedicates his attention to higher and more essential matters. Being visible to others does not hinder him; seeing and being seen was in his day unmediated and direct, and was a threat neither to his integrity nor to his personal secrets. It is not coincidental that this painting is a significant source of inspiration to the artists of Observatorium. They strive to restore the unmediated observation both of the individual and of the surroundings in the 21st century.

In the middle of public space, visible to outsiders and to oneself, they offer a place for contemplation and for peering out at the world, for mystery and transparency, for a synthesis of opposites – for the kind of reality we experienced long ago under the kitchen table.

Chapter 5

The Work is Not Finished Until Someone Uses It
Vught, 2003
Public square for De Leij Judicial Juvenile Institution, Vught

The Work is Not Finished Until Someone Uses It
Observatorium is fond of a lively atmosphere and appreciates it if people expand or modify their projects and sculptures. The basis for a public sculpture is established by a claim on space. The basis for a lively public space is appropriation by people.

Deprived of Liberty
De Leij Judicial Juvenile Institution, Vught, is a place where delinquent youths less than 18 years are remanded while awaiting a judicial sentence. It was decided to expand it by adding a school and a playground. The Atelier of the Government Architect, manages the one percent rule (in which a proportion of the budget for every government building project is reserved for art) on behalf of the Dutch government, decided to commission a work of art from Observatorium. “Just come up with a proposal,” it was implied, “our minds are open to anything.”

A crowd of security staff, teachers, office workers, psychologists and youth social workers gathers daily in front of the entrance to De Leij, in Vucht, to dedicate themselves to the problems of some 80 young people. The staff has a minute-by-minute daily programme of education, guidance and observation. A glimpse of all the security cameras, fences, walls, security gates and checkpoints gives you an impression of the human urge towards freedom. It takes an immense effort to deprive someone of their liberty.

After Observatorium’s first visits to this surrealistic world of protocols, curbs and solicitude, the artists came to see the young detainees as their primary patrons and decided to try ameliorating life behind the walls. A meeting with the director of the institution bolstered their determination. Madeleine van Toorenburg gave the artists a glowing description: “We are strict here and it is an intimidating environment, but our duties include schooling and personal development of our charges. Young though they are, they arrive here as aggressive, confused and angry adolescents. They deserve punishment, but they deserve even more compassion. I hope the work of art will give them a chance to be children again.”

Building Site I
How do you improve the world in a place as notorious as “Vucht”, as the location is widely nicknamed after the town? Since 1940, it has continually expanded to accommodate more and more involuntary residents. According to the demands of the times and the regime, there has been a continual process of building, expansion and demolition, on behalf of the banished, the uprooted and the incarcerated.

This was once a point on a line of fortifications intended to stave off the advance of Napoleon’s army. During the Second World War, it became a concentration camp and a transit camp. After the war, following the expulsion of the Netherlands from its colonies in Indonesia, it provided temporary abodes for loyal soldiers from the Moluccas; a year later the unfortunate soldiers were moved out to make way for complexes of prison cells. Continual construction of prisons for all kinds of incarceration and reeducation took place here since the 1970s. The woods around the prison complex are a backdrop to monuments, a memorial site and a museum, all of which are dedication to the respective relationships the Netherlands has had in the past with France, Germany and Indonesia. History also had its impact on Observatorium’s work of art: the artists were asked if they would be so kind as not to refer to the war – it was already bad enough here.

Building Site II
The continual alterations to Vucht, an aspiration to do some good and an environment for children persuaded the artists to apply their artistic freedom to occupying as large an area of land as possible. Guards, staff members and worried parents must realize as they enter the institution that they are in an environment designed for the children. Surrounded by walls, fences and grim buildings, Observatorium's collective eyes fell on a large site between three buildings (the staff offices, the cells for young detainees and the visiting rooms). What would it be like if here, in sight of the parents, children, social workers and guards, there were to be a domain of relative freedom? We would have to ensure that the work of art was unfinished; it would be up to the children to finish it as they saw fit. We would just lay the foundations. As a symbol of the fact that the prison premises belongs essentially to three groups of people, we decided that these foundations would copy the ground plans of the visitors centre, the cells and the offices.

Inside and outside
Observatorium was surprised to discover that the sealed-off world of Judicial Institutions features regularly in the news. Society is on the other side of the walls; here, the law, social trends and moral issues surface regularly, out of everyone's sight. There are plenty of reports in the media but contact through the walls is impossible. This sparked off the idea of enhancing the contacts through the walls; if the kids cant get out here, we will bring the world inside. This principle was first applied during construction of the foundations for Public Square for De Leij. The work of art was designated as a building site for apprentices. Young trainee masons from inside and outside the institution formed a building team together with the artists. The idea itself was an inspiring one. It was possible to invite young people from outside to learn a craft within the institution walls, and the young inmates had a chance to make contact with others of their own age.

Workshop
Completion of the foundations marked only the halfway point in the project. Now it was time to generate proposals, additions and individual initiatives. Workshops were organized with the aim of learning what significance the work of art might have for the young inmates. All 80 youths filled in a questionnaire prepared by Observatorium, and submitted their own designs for what was to be built on the foundations. Three proposals, all of which were supported by several individual inmates, were chosen for implementation. They were a desert island for chilling out, a garden with trees, flowers and vegetables, and a garage containing an escape car. The fruit trees in the garden flourished, the palm tree was a success and the car exerted a magical attraction on the youngsters. The social workers and teachers who had supported the artists in their efforts to reach all the children were enthusiastic, and offered their own ideas for uses of the Plaza. On completion, it looked colourful and inviting.

Discovery
One thing Observatorium had forgotten about was the aura of art. The staff of the institution started raising questions after the work was completed. Who was to maintain it? Were people allowed to sit on it? Can we propose changes? The whole process had concentrated on youth participation. To the young detainees, it was a matter of course that the foundations were an object for their own use – not that of their supervisors – and the latter had all received a memo to that effect. Once the staff had heard from the artists that the foundations were meant to be built up further, it was unnecessary to tell them that officially. The news spread like wildfire through the institution. Once the work of art was accepted for use, the work of Observatorium was at an end.

The first harvest took place a year later. After another year, Public Square for De Leij had become a functional training farm with about sixty farm animals and countless hand made shelters, fences, works of art and barns. Now anyone can see as they enter De Leij that the countryside of the surrounding

region of Brabant, with its vegetable gardens, pastures, barns full of odds and ends and pieces of Outsider Art, has found its way inside.

Chapter 6

Cultivate Conflict

The Memory of Parijsch
Culemborg, 2005
in collaboration with Sjaak Langenberg

You must actually judge an environment for its capacity to absorb and retain memories for the future. Whether that is the case is something that can be determined only in retrospect. As a designer, one can only wait and see what time will do to ones designs.
From J.J. Beljon, *Twaalf omgevingen*, Amsterdam 1976

Cultivate Conflict
Conflict and rancour exist alongside harmony and civilization. Art does not choos, but worms its way between these opposites and makes proposals for coexistence. Turn antitheses into ostensible antitheses.

Collaboration
The Municipality of Culemborg invited three artists to make acquaintance with the VINEX estate of Parijsch. They asked the artists what they would take as a theme if they ware commissioned to make a work of art in the public space. These statements would provide a basis for selecting the recipient of the commission. The investigations of Sjaak Langenberg and Observatorim both exposed a classic example of the outspokenness and power of individual citizens. An appeal had been lodged against municipal traffic plans, and various judicial bodies passed judgement on the issue; the outcome was a road barrier in the central link transit road, forcing nearly half the residents of the new estate to take a long way round when driving to the centre. The barrier itself looked temporary, but, after years of procedures, the Council of State decision in favour of the residents was a permanent one.

The patron and the Art Committee asked Langenberg and Observatorium whether, considering their shared interest in the impact of a minute pyramid in the middle of the road, they would be prepared to cooperate. They consented, for they were familiar with one another's work and saw a prospect of synergy between Observatorium's constructions and participation processes, and Langenberg's poetic films and performances.

Country Road
The matter is clear. The citizens have won their cause and the authorities have lost. There will be no more through traffic on this road although it has existed for centuries and is the shortest route between the city and the suburb. However, the more new homes that are built on the outer side of the barrier, the more new residents there will be to fume over the victory of their neighbours. Any new initiative would be pointless, however, since those who have exacted the right to a low-traffic road are entitled to sue for damages if the obstacle is removed. The municipality is powerless. Langenberg and Observatorium had unearthed a culture of protest and mutual suspicion. The disputes had been simmering for seven years (and still continue to the date of writing, September 2009). It was not easy to ignore the furious protests; as usual, the public debate was dominated by the loud voices of those who felt disadvantaged, and the imperturbability of the local government representatives. When interviewing people around the impediment, the artists noted that not everyone objected to it; on the contrary, quite a few people were delighted that the country road remained a quiet byway despite the mushrooming growth in the number of residents and cars.

School Playground

The municipality implemented the decision of the *Hoge Raad*, the Dutch Supreme Court, by blocking the road with fencing, concrete blocks, reflectors, white bricks, a traffic light and a movable barrier. It looked like a temporary fix, despite the decree being irrevocable. It was in any case hard to imagine a greater contrast with the careful urban design of the surrounding suburb.

Amid the bickering about the traffic barrier, it would easy to lose sight of the fact that the barrier separated two schools and a child daycare centre. Several times a day, crowds of parents arrive by car and bicycle to deposit or collect their children. These are important social moments for the local community. The parents get to know one another and the new housing estate soon ceases to be such an anonymous environment. The crowds of waiting parents prompted the idea of surrounding the road barrier on both sides with seats, so giving the area between the schools the informal atmosphere like that typifies the pavement cafés of Dutch city squares. It would be a waiting area for parents, with boxes as seats, and at the same time an extension of the school playgrounds. The terrace would in effect put a frame around the conflict and the clumsy urban design, changing the permanent emergency measure into a convivial social venue. Since the artists had heard from various quarters that, despite the decree, the barrier might some day be removed, the boxes would serve as containers for the barrier materials, which would in that case be preserved as a memorial. As Sjaak Langenberg put it, “We will be taking a rain check on history with this monument to the first battle of Parijsch. We aim to turn the roadblock into an emblem of the neighbourhood which marks a significant point in its history.”

Making History

The artists designated the conflict as the first historic battle of VINEX. It would be a monument to something that might disappear in the future. When we presented this idea to the Muncipality, Mr. Burger, a councillor, was amused by the idea that this idea would amount to a culturalization of his dispute with the local residents. He freely offered to extend the artistic commission, asking us also to provide a landmark for the entry point of the shopping centre.

Several features of Parijsch were doomed to disappear in the course of development, namely the farmyards and barns in the area around the new retail zone. Langenberg and Observatorium decided to create a second reminder of the early days of the Parijsch housing estate. It would be the skeleton of a barn, with an attic containing boxes of archeological data. The structure is situated in a small orchard adjacent to the entry to the shopping centre. The attic is supported on a structure of cross-braced steel members. The work of art is lit in green and red, as a sign of the barn’s connection with the traffic lights of the barrier. The artists asked for the shopping centre bus stop to be placed directly opposite the sculpture. The more varied the use of the space, the better.

“We did not find a narrative here,” Sjaak Langenberg stated, “but we are making history. We are building a wooden deck, identical to that of the terrace, at right angles to Prijsseweg. But the floor will not be at ground level but elevated four metres above it. The floor will double as an attic, a communal attic for the neighbourhood. An attic is where people put things they want to keep, things they just cannot part with or know they will need some day. We are placing a number of wooden boxes in this attic, and they will contain a complete edition of a postdated newspaper. The newspaper will be printed in 2005, but the 13 thousand copies will not be distributed to the households of Culemborg until 2025.”

Future

The newspaper contains interviews with inhabitants of the town of Culemborg. It will be published in the future, but it is about the present day. Did they expect to feel regrets about anything, we asked them. Were they worried about illness or death? How would they look back to the first historic events of this neighbourhood in twenty years time? What personal histories from far and wide have mingled in this district? What kind of future do they expect for themselves? What would they like their children to recall of this period in twenty years’ time? The contents of the newspaper will remain secret for 20 years.

Culemborgse Courant, a newspaper with roots in the town going back to 1860, cooperated with the artists in producing it. The special edition is the first historical record of the new district of Parijsch. Sjaak Langenberg and Andre Dekker made repeated trips to explore Parijsch and its surroundings between May and September 2005, noting their observations and interviewing people. The images in *Culemborgse Courant 2025* are by the photographer Awoiska van der Molen. She made portraits of local residents of Parijsch as it was in 2005. At the unveiling of the sculpture on 16 December 2025, the Mayor promised, the boxes in the attic would be opened and the newspapers would be distributed door to door in Culemborg. It would be decided at the same time what new contents the boxes must have. Hopefully the artists and the photographer will live to witness the day.

Chapter 7

Design What There Is
Neukirchen-Vluyn, 2006
Hallenhaus, Norddeutschland Slag Heap, Neukirchen-Vluyn

Design What There Is
Emptiness and silence are hard to design. When they are available, Observatorium incorporates these characteristics into the design. There are three ways to do it: do nothing, protect them and make them visible.

[quote]
Unambiguous though it might seem, the barn remains something of an enigma.
Malcolm Kirk, *Silent Spaces. The Last of the Great Aisled Barns*, Boston, 1994

Nice story
In Berlin, preparations for Observatorium's *Autorenwerkstatt* exhibition were interrupted by an unannounced visit by Marie Cathleen Haff, a member of the Dutch Embassy staff. She requested information and took some of Observatorium's slides with her to illustrate a lecture on contemporary art in the Netherlands. She later heard about the design for *Nieuw Terbregge Observatory*, and included an article about it in an embassy publication on contemporary Dutch landscape architecture. She was also responsible for putting the Observatorium artists in touch with Thies Schröder, an organizer of symposiums and an editor of publications about landscape architecture. He invited Observatorium to take part in a panel debate in Potsdam. Even before the start of the debate, Andre Deker and Prof. Hinnerk Wehberg fell into an animated discussion. The professor ended the day by suggesting to the Observatorium artists "How about collaborating on a competition entry?" One year later, the newcomers to the discipline of art in the public space found themselves part of a team together with WES+Partner, a large landscape architecture firm from Hamburg. And, a year after that, they won the commission to remodel a huge plateau-like slag heap, 80 metres tall and 100 hectares in area, a relic of the coal mining industry near the Ruhr.

The project
Halde Norddeutschland is a designated node in a network of sports and recreational facilities for the multi-million population of the Ruhr region in the Niederrhein landscape. Closure of the coal mines caused considerable unemployment in Niederrhein, situated between the Ruhr and the Dutch border. The urban planner Thomas Sieverts, known for the term *Zwischenstadt* and the book of that title (referring to a sprawling, incoherent style of development which is neither town nor country), drew up a plan to promote leisure development in the area: Landschaftspark Niederrhein. Halde Norddeutschland is a centrally located attraction within this plan. It is a parkland area suitable for walking, cycling, paragliding, equestrian sport and much else. It is also intended to attract investors in recreational amenities. The core aims of the project were threefold: integration of the slag heap into the landscape, development of the heap into a recreational facility (which would generate new jobs) and creation of a landmark.

Mount of Silence
WES+Partner and Observatorium were so impressed by the landscape potential of the slag heap, that they chose *Kein Remmidemmi* (no tumult or noise) as a motto for their design. The heap must not be turned into a plinth for the leisure industry, but into a place for contemplation. If building had to take place there, then it ought to be something for monks and seekers after tranquillity. Instead of using the

elevation to build toboggan runs and restaurants, the designers visualized a monastery with a central courtyard. WES+Partner found a monastic community whose members were amenable to relocation, and pulled out all the stops to convince the committee of the importance of peace, quiet and wellness. They marked the vanished river courses around the mount with large circles of trees, and designed a *Himmelsleiter* (Jacob's Ladder) monument. Observatorium designed a landmark for the location. The design won the first prize, but then it had to be adapted quickly to the reality of a declining economy. Provisionally, funds were available only for the landmark, a car park and the Jacob's Ladder.

Hallenhaus

The idea for the landmark was born when the artists looked into *Silent Spaces*, a book about the history of barn building by the photographer Malcolm Kirk. One particular photo attracted their interest – the reassembly of the Deertz Barn on a hilltop in upstate New York. The space surrounding the wooden skeleton of the barn reminded them of the spatial sensation of a temple or cathedral.

Pioneering Dutch and German immigrants to the USA had between them developed a new type of barn which blended their two traditions. The resulting "Dutch barn" was based on the *los hoes*, a Saxon farmhouse type with an unpartitioned interior which also occurs in the east of the Netherlands, and the *Hallenhaus* (hall house) from Lower Saxony in Germany, characterized by division into a central hall and two side bays. The hall house is a variant of an ancient architectural type which developed in the course of history into a practical building for agriculture, industry and residence, and was also used for ecclesiastical purposes. The hall house typically had three uses: grain storage, stalling of livestock and housing for the farming family.

A Dutch barn in Germany

Observatorium is fond of open structures in both literal and figurative senses. An open form enables the user/spectator to complete add to the work in his or her imagination. A sculpture by Observatorium is seldom finished on delivery. It is designed so that people can add to its structure or transform it for their own use. The *Hallenhuis* sculpture consists of steel trusses and can be completely disassembled. The component elements, each of which consists of twelve lightweight beams, can be unscrewed without any danger that the remainder will collapse. Two sections were extracted from the overall structure and placed alongside the *Hallenhuis*, which is actually just a big construction kit. The structure rests on a concrete plinth which provides seating space all around.

Large as the *Hallenhuis* appears to someone standing in its interior, it seems little more than a pencil sketch when viewed from below. It tells passing motorists on the A57 Autobahn that, after 50 years of being terra incognita, the huge mound is now accessible and is a place from which you can look back at the mundane world whenever you feel like standing outside it. The *Hallenhuis* can also be regarded as a structure that frames emptiness and expansiveness. Despite its overall size, it succeeds in underlining the design team's wish to keep the mount as empty as possible.

Panorama

Emptiness and silence can be hard to design, and when these qualities are present, the design must aim to protect them. It is important to realize how much mystery and how much perfection a non-designed space possesses. For an incipient recreational facility, for a district which is subject to major economic developments and, especially, for a region where huge power stations mingle with historic farmhouses, the incomplete building is a symbol of change and optimism. Observatorium's *Hallenhuis* frames the splendid panorama and gives the bare mount a distinct identity. Despite the openness of the structure, the sculpture feels like an interior with picture windows. It exerts a concentrated force on many visitors. The subtle blend of sanctity and profanity that every large barn possesses is all the more conspicuous here due to the Acropolis-like setting.

Open-air university

During the period of construction of the *Hallenhuis* and the *Himmelsleiter*, Observatorium received more and more invitations from universities and other higher education institutes. Quite often, following a lecture on the project, students would rush to their computers to seek reference images and existing solutions. When Jacob Voorthuis, a specialist in architecture theory at Eindhoven University of Technology, gave Observatorium a free hand in arranging a workshop course there, a desire arose to go outdoors and to address as much paradox as possible: reality awareness versus amazement, and free design versus communal consciousness. The *Hallenhaus* and the slag heap were declared an open university. The students paid two visits to the pioneering landscape, and were assigned the following task: to take up residence on the mount and make an ideal house, bearing in mind that the settlement is on public ground and that the panorama from the top of the mount is a valuable asset. Two suggestions were offered for consideration: don't just take from the mount, but also give to the mount; and incorporate a division between public and private into your building.

Freedom of establishment on the recreation site yielded some intriguingly paradoxical designs: a cemetery with a caretaker's dwelling, a public library with upper floor dwelling on a public road, and a villa with a swimming pool that doubles as a gatehouse. The exercise yielded some exciting proposals in which the private interests of free establishment went hand in hand with an enrichment of the public space.

Chapter 8

A Sculpture is Ideally Three Things
Rotterdam, 1997
Perron Mozaïque, Hofplein Station, Rotterdam

A Sculpture is Ideally Three Things
A Sculpture is ideally three things: a work of imagination, a reflection on the surroundings and a contribution to communal cohesion. It is there to be accepted and experienced, it discloses the nature of the context and motivates action.

[quotes]

The Hofplein public plaza will be the focus of urban life: a public space which was never previously designed, a node arisen by chance, buzzing with life and enlivened by two access routes to the stations. It is a Gordian Knot for generations of urban planners and architects.
Frits Palmboom, *Rotterdam- verstedelijkt landschap* (Rotterdam, 1987)

I end then in praise of small spaces. The multiplier effect is tremendous. It is not just the number of people using them, but the larger number who pass by and enjoy them vicariously, or even the larger number who feel better about the city center for knowledge of them. For a city, such places are priceless, whatever the cost. They are built of a set of basics and they are right in front of our noses. If we will look.
William H. White (Washington D.C., 1980)

Sleeping in Art
The Motel Mozaïque Music Festival was first organized under the aegis of Rotterdam Capital of Culture 2001. From the outset, the director Harry Hamelink put hospitality foremost. Rotterdam's warm reception of thousands of contemporary popular music and art enthusiasts was an essential aspect of

the festival. The festival presented the city by day, and at night everyone had a ball. The “sleeping in art” component became proverbial. It started with people spending the night in works of art in the TENT gallery. The first time Observatorium was invited to take part in the sleep-in, they took the subtitle of the festival, *The City as Platform*, as literally as possible. They sought space in the streets between the festival locations, teeming with hospitality. Could the city provide hospitality without having to make a work of art to achieve it? When this question was considered, the brightly lit interiors of the closed shops resembled high-class hotel rooms; what a waste to use the space in the daytime only, the Observatorium artists decided. In 2003, 16 shops, one bar and one catering establishment were combined to form *Hotel Diorama*. A night porter, with a huge bunch of keys to the shops and alarm systems rattling on his chest, kept watch in the street. In 2007, 2008 and 2009, Observatorium again took responsibility for offering members of the festival audience places to sleep in places where Rotterdam was unfinished: the building excavations at Museumpark, the Architecture Institute island and the sleeping beauty of Hofplein Station.

Arrival in Rotterdam

The construction pits around Rotterdam Centraal Station prompted Motel Mozaïque to adopt “arrival in the city” as a theme of its activities; they asked Observatorium to create a sleeping place for a second time. A limited competition was initated for a design for meeting points in the stations of the new High Speed Rail line. The Observatorium artists were keen to think about the challenge, *hors concours*, and took the opportunity of the commission to design a meeting point for Rotterdam Centraal Station. The first, self-imposed requirement was that a train passenger arriving at the meeting point must experience something of the flavour of Rotterdam before leaving the station. The large, complex building works in the area around the central station certainly did not present any ideal locations (in the construction pits, on a raised platform above the existing station platforms?) for overnight stays. Then another station in the centre of Rotterdam entered the picture – one that was to be decommissioned in a few years’ time. There was enough room there, and the helpful owners were open to ideas from outsiders. At Hofplein Station, it would be possible to make a platform rising high above the surrounding station structure, so that people arriving at the station could immediately enjoy a panoramic view of Rotterdam.

Location

Hofplein Station is a nationally listed building in the middle of the city, and it is in a dilapidated condition. Planned abolition of the elevated railway to The Hague was to be the salvation of Rotterdam’s longest building. Four housing corporations joined forces to purchase the station from the Dutch Railways with the intention of turning it into a “crafts/cultural backbone” for the densely built surrounding housing estates. The terminus of the line is only a stone’s throw from the city centre but is completely cut off from it. It is presently in a run-down condition although it was once one of the city’s liveliest areas. The view from *Perron Mozaique* would give a good idea of the buildings, highways and tunnel that had gradually isolated the station from city life. Four years before the actual start of the planned conversion project in 2010, it was possible to gain an idea of the constrained situation and the potentials of Hofplein Station.

Programme of activities

Rotterdam declared itself a City of Architecture in 2007. Forty of the city’s prominent postwar buildings were draped in purple ribbons and opened to the public. To emphasize the status of *Perron Mosaique* as a proposal in built form, the temporary platform was entirely clad in purple floor covering material and was officially declared the 41st building of the city’s architecture route. Its central location made it attractive to numerous visitors, but the aim was for it to be used as diversely and intensively as possible. It was therefore furnished as a bed and breakfast facility, as a lookout point and as a venue for debates and music. At breakfast, the overnight guests would receive a questionnaire to complete.

Several leading lights of the Rotterdam hip hop scene put in an appearance at *Perron Mozaique*: DuvelDuvel, the rapper Bolle Tim and Mike Redman. The programme also included graffiti art by All Art Works, rap workshops given by Bolle Rapper Tim, breakdancing by Breakers Anonymous and performances of the dance group Bond van Wilde Dansers. Sunday was a day of intellectual activities, with a guest lecture on philosophy by Jacob Voorthuis under the title *Welcoming City*, a rapid course on Rotterdam's urban planning by Patrick van der Klooster, and the performance of a poem, compiled from answers to the questionnaire, by the Belgian cultural diva Claire Beke.

Three things

The platform of *Perron Mosaique* rose like a ski jump from the elevated railway of the Hofplein Line to high above the surrounding infrastructure, marking the point of arrival in the city. The elevated platform offered a magnificently central view of the reconstruction works going on in Rotterdam. It was a temporary piece of "wild" urban design for a city that is never finished. The platform, the space where people take their first steps in the city, was a monument of hospitality, linking the space of arrival with the space of the city.

The ideal of a sculpture that simultaneously had a public use and was a pragmatic item in the city environment, was a reality for the period of three days. It was a valued contribution to Rotterdam's self-image as a city of festivals. Quays, streets or squares in the inner city are cleared of traffic dozens of times a year to make room for tents, generators, loudspeakers, stalls and crowds of pedestrians. Rotterdam has ample ill-defined or neglected space which can play host to spectacles and urban promotion; cannot these spectacles contribute to the culture of the built environment?

The visitors to *Perron Mozaique* included the programme committee of the De Parade theatre festival. They took up the challenge to debate seriously with Observatorium on the urbanism and culture of Rotterdam.

Collaboration

A hotel for 200 guests, entertainments, workshops and guided tours of the railway station added up to a programme that the three artists could not organize alone. Observatorium collaborated on *Perron Mozaique* with the TENT gallery, Rotterdam 2007 City of Architecture, RET/Randstadrail (owners of the station), Hofbogen BV (the future owners), the World Trade Center Club, the art producers Mothership, and the music festival Motel Mozaïque. The illusion of ad hoc, instant urbanism, was wholly dependent on a down-to-earth collaborative structure.

The elevated platform was itself made of scaffolding furnished with theatrical lighting and floor covering material. The bedrooms were made of wood and perspex. Overnight stay facilities were available in the bedrooms on the platform and in the now empty gambling clubs and dance bars that had meanwhile occupied the defunct station.

[responses by guests]

Perron Mozaique Questionnaire

Answers to the request for ideas about a new application for Hofplein Station, as compiled and designed by Observatorium.

I love anonymous areas like this, a street market, a floral meadow, ground left to the weeds, maybe with a toilet, a swimming pool and a car park.

Looks like a heart, integration of shops and museums, climbing apparatus with a stall, playground for grandads and grandmas, a park, flowers everywhere, lots of lights.

Art to think about, a big rehearsal hall, the new city hall (hurry up!), a motel for Motel Mozaique, house with a lookout tower, football park, hotbed.
Something like this, back to the past, a lively entertainment district, ticket booths, link Perron Hofplein to Centraal Station, a station clock, domed roof, light blue.

Platform ladies and gentlemen in white costumes, creating links, a long coffee table, the sunlight is always muted, dressing up the new as old.

A long, high footbridge, demolish the whole of Hofplein, get the train to Amsterdam, by the water in summer, ice rink in winter, more events, a giant architectural model.

Trolley from the kitchen to the terrace, a park for music marquees, a big gallery, little bars, place for artists, save history – build future.

A waiting room but not for the train, train carriage as restaurant, bridge with shops, escalators and slides, keeping things for everyone who loves life with no regrets, nobody in a hurry.

[contributed article]

The Possibility of a Generous City. An Exercise in Thinking About Politeness
Jacob Voorthuis

The way people in my surroundings read me is not the same as what is written in my face. My face appears to be only partly my own. The word *beleeft* [literally "polite", but also the past participle of *beleven*, to experience] is a rather loaded one in Dutch. *Beleven* [experiencing or being polite] is the lifestyle that I embody as a position towards the world. The more I conduct my life, the better I get at "experiencing". I know how to use things: water, read, a smile, an iPod, a house, a friendly word. I gather experience and polish, and I become polite. I get good at things, elegant and agile. Polite people are those who have practised with the world. Politeness is a familiarity with which what usages are successful and do not harm other people. Being polite is not hypocrisy, it is not an empty, formal behaviour, unless you make it that way. It can become hypocritical in the same way as any other practice which is repeated until nothing remains but an empty catechism, a ritual, a moral imperative of the kind Nietzsche described where not only is the original purpose is forgotten but people have turned against it out of misplaced piety; in which the original usage has situated the body as well as possible in space and the catechism emptied of meaning has become a subversive usage, a disciplining, which serves an obscure politic. Being polite, strange though it may sound, is one way to gain access to the generosity of the city-as-environment. The city is a personal collection of positions, gazes, perspectives and memories. To bring the city to life, it must be practised and experienced. The polite person plays the city the way Michael Jordan played basketball; he knows his limitations so well that they become freedoms.

The mankind-concerning, i.e. the useful, is a precondition for our reading of the surroundings. We seek the usage pattern in the Other. Realization of this opens the possibility of, and the need for, a generous city. The city offers us wealth as long as we are capable of appreciating it. The city offers its wealth for our use and is generous towards us. Having and being are aspects of use, as is enjoying. Having is having on loan, being is being in use, and enjoyment is, like pain, a sign. The city is the product of community, the behavioural form. The community is a network of relations in which public life and private life learn to relate to each other via the wall, the window and the door. Generosity plays a crucial political role in making the city work, for life in the city is a life in which sympathetic relationships must be stretched, in which they must reach further than "the family" without neglecting the latter; further

than the neighbourhood, further than this country, further than mankind; it reaches towards the infinite. Society has but one goal, to offer place[/accommodate]. Civilization is paper thin because society has to be learned and practised [by] everyone. That calls for maintenance... Thus if we wish to live together in the city, we must be generous towards one another and the city, and we must practise its implicit generosity, its rich world. Only then does the city become generous towards us. Beauty then turns out to be omnipresent.

To operate as a collective institution, the city must appeal to the individual. The city then becomes in the first place *my* city, in the sense of *my* beloved. Do you know *Hiroshima Mon Amour*, in which the lovers identify themselves with the cities from which they come? Hiroshima is the man, and Nevers, the woman. Hiroshima, destroyed but certain of its business, its priorities and direction, clearly and joyfully renewing itself in the memory of the unthinkably catastrophic; and Nevers, decayed, tired, old, full of rancour, uncertain and sad, but determined, and oh so human.

The more one constrains the city within a definition, the smaller and sharper, the larger and more diffuse and tragic, it becomes. A definition in its normative sense is almost always wedge-like. It gains thereby its dimension, shape, direction and goal. My city is hence a composition, a usage pattern, and thereby acquires a style, a foreground, a background, with subtle highlights and shadows, and a centre on which the attention rests, a manner of doing. The definition of a city, the description of a city, belongs to the metaphysics of finding. How does one find something? It depends on our poetic, scientific and artistic measurement of the usage-pattern by which the city offers its riches for plundering.

But what about the ugly city, the hated city, the tragic city? In many places in the city, it is impossible to appropriate the wealth that is available as pleasure. Other places are more unruly. If a place becomes beautiful, it bears a real danger because the perceived beauty cloaks life in picturesqueness. People who are polite know that such cloaking is both a pleasure and a shame. Every cloak uncloaks the shame. On the other hand, people who find things dull are capable of finding dullness. People who love find lovingness. This is the mechanics of "beingthere". The city that you find ugly, find oppressive, find inimical, says nothing about the city and everything about your finding.

It is not true that you yourself are ugly if you find a city ugly. Ugliness is simply what you perceive. You could just as well perceive something different. There are no rules for perceiving something. Your revulsion fills the city in your perceiving. And sometimes that is wholly comprehensible. Sometimes we just let go of the city, and no longer practise it. We give it up. We turn away from it. We divest ourselves of its wealth and become bitter, and are consumed with hate and revulsion. Or, worse still, we think we have found a solution, start believing in transcendency, in the higher.

And the artist, the architect or the urban designer: what is his role? He has a choice. He can maintain the physical structure of the city or he can make more city than is necessary; that is his role. How does he do that? He can opt for the known, for that which has been practised into culture. Then he must practise in what works well and what does not. In this respect, typology, tectonics, the collective architectural experience, the space-experience, helps. He must learn to transpose what works in one place to another, to a different context. Cities of this kind develop on the basis of what has proved itself. He can also opt for experiment, for making cities that are still to be learnt, cities that still have to be practised, the new. Which is better?

Chapter 9

Cella, Courtyard, Domain
Essen, 2007
Entrance Pavilion for Zollvereinpark, Essen

Cella, Courtyard, Domain

Diversity of space arouses curiosity and creates diversity of use. The succession of cella, courtyard and domain, phases the fluid links between inside and outside. Private and public are established in dialogue.

[quote]

It goes like this: architecture is rearranging material for human purposes. [...] I like it because it includes sculpture and machines in architecture as well as landscape and buildings.
Paul Shepheard, *Artificial Love: A Story of Machines and Architecture* (Cambridge Mass., 2003)

Nature versus culture
Zollverein is a world heritage site. The complex covers approximately 100 hectares of mine buildings, a coke oven, storage areas and railway marshalling yards. The gradual restoration of the buildings and their reassignment to new purposes is making Zollverein into an ever more lively centre of culture, tourism and design. While construction was in progress towards giving the huge machinery of the mine a second lease of life, a remarkable kind of wilderness developed here: industrial nature, a flora and fauna that feels at home in buildings, on polluted dry soil and on railway tracks. After architects such as Foster and Sanaa realized some distinctive buildings, Koolhaas plotted out a development strategy and Agence Ter supplied a master plan for the park, the Planergruppe Oberhausen team won the competition for implementation of the master plan. Four disciplines are represented within the team: landscape architecture (Planergruppe Oberhausen), communications design (Firstdesign), lighting architecture (Licht Kunst Licht) and art (Observatorium). The jury awarded this team the implementation project on account of the high level of accessibility given to the site for local residents and tourists alike, the circumspect means used in the landscape architecture, the simplicity of the lighting and the unorthodox plan that unified communications (signposting and routing) with art. It was evident that the beauty of the weed-overgrown site and the dilapidated machinery could not be preserved. What mattered was to make room for hundreds of thousands of visitors while designing sparsely, so that nature would be able to keep the leading role it had claimed. The landscape architecture design of Planergruppe Oberhausen moreover brought an end to the gradual invasion of nature by an astonishing ensemble of buildings[?]. Industrial nature was to a large extent left to its own devices. And that was the core of the design: where it was really impossible to leave the natural situation undisturbed, gardening was to be carried out by observing and selecting, rather than by planting.

Unorthodox
Since the raw industrial character and the efficient architecture of Zollverein constituted the core of the complex, circumspection was appropriate in the communication design. If it is so difficult to find your way, one could reason, then there is only one solution: not signs but people. The site is so extensive and complex, and the functions are so diverse, that people are needed to show visitors the way. Here, of all places, where a high point in the mechanization of production put humanity in the shade, it was desirable to reintroduce the human dimension. Male and female hosts were to stand ready where the visitors arrive to show them the way, to hand out information and to help them however required. Observatorium designed entrance pavilions for the park, each with its own garden and mine shaft, for these people. This was the artistic contribution to the park. The jury saw this novel idea as unorthodox and appealing, but no provision had been made for appointing staff as part of the Zollvereinpark construction project. It took extensive discussions and years of patience before permission was given to expend some of the budget reserved for signposting on human resources.

On the border
The rules for the park applied naturally to the pavilion too: circumspection in materials and form, and respect for what was already present. All other requirements, as regards functions and meanings, were

left to the artists to formulate. A visitor to Zollverein will discover that the complex is surrounded by sprawling working-class suburbs of the city of Essen. The impressive piece of world heritage is inseparable from the low-income estates, which house the former mineworkers and their families. A study of the housing estates led Observatorium to its first self-imposed requirement: the pavilions must bond with the residential surroundings.

The buildings of Zollverein are pragmatic and modular. The architects, Schupp and Kremmer, employed a complicated set of standard proportions for the grid, and chose steel, concrete, glass and brick as their building materials. Observatorium's study of the architecture suggested a second self-imposed requirement: the pavilions should be modular and made of similar materials. Schupp and Kremmer's original purpose, to create a perfect machine for the mining industry, had resulted not only in beautiful architecture; the placing of the buildings was also meant make the labourers invisible to the outside world. This was a key consideration for Obervatorium: the pavilions must reinstate the visibility of the employed workers, while also creating a relationship between the housing estates and the mine premises.

The artisan's dwellings built in the Ruhr prior to World War 2 were arranged in garden villages around the mine. The workers had fairly small houses but they often had a small private garden for growing vegetables and a stall for animals. The mine worker was a cog in the machine but at home he was a smallholder. And that implied requirement 3: each pavilion must have a garden and a stall, so that the information worker of Zollverein Tourism would have a personal estate to uphold as he or she saw fit. This would ensure that visitors to Zollverein would receive a personal welcome before entering the gigantic site full of buildings and machinery.

To sum up, the task the artists set themselves was to design a pavilion as a hybrid of the worker's living and working situation, a transition between the home and the factory. The host should have a personal domain into which to welcome visitors and inform them about Zollverein.

A kind of architecture

How can one build an entrance pavilion which is inviting but is intimate in scale? Observatorium's answer was to give it an architecture that suggests rather than encloses: no roof, no walls, no openings in the walls; not a building at all, in other words, but something that can nonetheless stand the test of time. The designers therefore decided to use concrete, the building material used for the shafts of the coal washer building opposite. The height, width and depth of the pavilions would be a scaled-down version of the Zollverein proportions.

Four upright, rectangular frames were placed adjacently to form a house, a large horizontal element formed the fence of a garden and a stack of five square frames made up a stall. As a contrast with regular architecture and for the sake of individual expression, all the elements were angled horizontally in relation one another and the stall was slightly tilted vertically. The ensemble of forms was then surrounded by a rectangular concrete margin, setting it subtly apart from the surroundings like a detached house. A square vitrine, intended to give the host some shelter and to allow the pavilion to function as a showcase, was inserted into the composition as a separate element. The hybrid of intimacy and industry was maintained throughout by making a space with the dimensions of a porter's lodge, using steel sections of the kind used for building factories. The pavilions had doors weighing 150 kilos, for example.

The form, dimensions, placing and articulation hence emerged from the imperative to involve the architectural styles of the artisan's dwelling and the mining complex. The only item missing from the resulting composition was colour. The concrete of the pavilion is grey and the brickwork of the houses and the mine buildings is brown. This was where the lighthearted game of hybridization came to an end. After all the formal decisions, it was time for a choice with an uncertain outcome. Geert had once made a sculpture in which two different colours of concrete were poured, one on top of the other, into a mould. The marbled effect he had obtained then provide a pleasing contrast with the angularity of the

pavilion, and it could be interpreted as a reference to the geological layers of the Ruhr. The resulting pattern of white, grey and black concrete was not only aesthetically appealing, but unintendedly referred to the coal mining activities that were the origin of the whole exercise. Even before it was complete, a passer-by remarked that it was a successful imitation of the concrete shafts of the coal washer. In the course of decades, the transportation of millions of tons of coal had produced a black/grey surface on the white concrete, and this had been preserved for aesthetic reasons during conversion of the coal washer into a museum.

Cella, courtyard, domain

Observatorium has not probed the full depths of Dom Hans van der Laan's architectural theories, but sees standpoints in his writings that appear to have a universal validity. That the house is a culmination of nature is one such observation. We do not have a true creative power such as nature has but we transform that which is already present in the Creation. A house is therefore nothing but a subtraction of space from the whole. Clearly, the house must therefore remain bound to the space from which it is carved out. Windows and doors are therefore not enough. One can aspire to an articulation of space in which the exterior is in the thrall of the interior.

Dom Hans van der Laan designed only one house, Villa Naalden in Best (NL). Observatorium paid it a visit. A striking aspect is the large amount of space that strictly speaking has no part in the act of dwelling as we understand it. There is a surplus of space to walk through, and a relative shortage of space to sit down in. The circulation space of the house consists of a hall, a corridor and a walled garden, which is apparently derived from cloister architecture. But Van der Laan sought to create an ever-growing awareness of our being in the world, and the house was a vehicle towards that realization. We perceive, we move and we acquire understanding. These purposes are served by a house. He linked perception to the domain of the house, movement to the courtyard and insight to the cella.

Pavilion Zollverein has a similar subdivision. The whole stands in a domain that spurns the extensiveness of the world. The courtyard, which links all the spaces together, is an invitation to motion. The cella is the showcase in which concentration is possible. The only thing that is missing, in Van der Laan's terms, is the absolute inner zone. But just as the design plays with the notions of industry and dwelling, theory and chance are here part of a game. Now it is up to the hosts of Zollverein to appropriate the pavilion for their own use and play with it. Between interior and exterior lies the transition between private and public.

Chapter 10
The World, As It Is Told

Villagescape, Heino
2007–2008

A study towards preserving the village-like character, as part of the *Rafels, Randen en Routes* project by Atelier Overijssel.

"Is it our aim to take on the shaping of the landscape as a deliberate form of cultural action?"
Bernard Colenbrander in *De Uitvinding van het uiterwaardenmodel [The Invention of the Flood Plain Model]*, Hans Venhuizen

"A nondescript soup of red [housing] and green [open country] will in the long run yield a situation in which nobody wins."
Dirk Sijmons, in *Cultuur en stadelijke vernieuwing [Culture and Urban Renewal]*, 2004.

The World, As It Is Told
Observatorium makes sculpture for observing the world. It has to be used. If you want to show people what you have made, you have to demonstrate how to use it and what can result by doing so.

Villages in landscapes
Villages in the Dutch province of Overijssel very widely in their layout and their origins. Since the 1950s, all the historic village centres have become embedded in a uniform sprawl of terraced housing, industry parks and ring roads. This was a result of worthy intentions such as providing good, inexpensive housing for the whole population and banishing through traffic from town centres. How could they break out of the vicious circle in which good intentions led only to poorly designed urban environments?

Atelier Overijssel, a provincial think tank based in Zwolle, commissioned seven landscape architects to sketch their ideal spatial developments for seven different villages. These visions, combined with a historical overview, were meant to help enrich the culture of spatial planning and stimulate the local authorities to reconsider their approach. Observatorium was invited to make a "thing" which would make the spatial planning issues palpable, to be placed near the exhibition of the work of the landscape architects in Nijenhuis Castle in Heino. Would Observatorium be able to seduce the outdoor public into perceiving and appreciating the dilemmas facing landscape architecture?

Plans
The field of landscape architecture nowadays goes beyond landscape design alone, and addresses the neighbouring universe of spatial planning, most of whose plans will never be implemented because they are made only as studies, options or competition entries. Economic welfare permits us the luxury of visions, consultations, studies and participation. Landscapes which are subject to potential change tend however to be peopled by working committees alighting from tourist coaches, rather than visionaries scanning the horizon. A wise inscription on ancient Roman roadside tombs was in its day apparently so widely neglected that it had to be stated in the imperative: *siste viator*. Observatorium boiled down the task of providing a palpable experience of spatial planning to making a place for travellers to stop and observe, at the village margin of Heino. It would be a place for pondering the borderlines between built-up and open country, between people and animals, between "red" and "green". All that remained to decide was where, when, how, for whom, together with whom, and why.

Village edge

The edge of a village [??/silhouette] in the Netherlands is a calligraphy of trees, houses and a church steeple, far away on the horizon. That is also an ideal. In Heino one encounters a surprising inversion of this ideal, where, instead of lying on the horizon and being surrounded by countryside, the green landscape penetrates to the centre of the village to reach the church. The leading tip of this green wedge is a meadow fringed with oak trees. The archetypical trees, the houses and the church tower are visible from the meadow. The discovery of a nineteenth century painting of the village margin of Heino did the rest[?]. The painting shows the small figure of a man standing on a road leading to the village on the horizon. Observatorium reasoned that if the landscape architect is responsible for devising a development scenario for the village in the distance, then it would be our job contribute to an intense perception of the village on the part of its inhabitants. A decision was taken to reconstruct both the dark road and the dark, contemplative figure so that the residents of Heino would themselves form the central point of the scene. Three pavilions were added to provide shelter along the dark road; these would look out in different directions from different heights, like architectural eyes.

The elevated position of the road, the donkeys and the observation pavilions left the meadow and the surroundings ostensibly untouched, preserving a distance between the spectator and the landscape. If you put up a building and receive guests, then you also have to appoint a host. Observatorium decided to take that role and the volunteer emerged: Andre Dekker himself would be P. Visser. His duty was to keep the pavilions heated, receive visitors, tell people about the artistic project and explaine his own presence. He would turn into that lonely figure standing still in a field, observing the world and surrendering to the byproduct of stillness – the perception of oneself. Anyone looking at Heino from here, in the middle of Heino, has left Heino.

Occupying space

The fence around the meadow was cut through, and a fence with the name P. Visser was placed there. Above the no-man's land, of which nobody knew that it was the church who leased it to a farmer, a private domain was constructed. The road and the plateaux were made of scaffolding and black carpet. The pavilions were wooden structures with perspex windows which were sprayed from top to bottom with bitumen. For a short while the holy meadow supported buildings, and people could look at the village and the road from the emptiness. Someone pausing there had no choice but to look out over the space, as from the centre of an eye. Standing on the edge of the Villagescape, one could see that the meadow was fringed on all sides by large oak trees. On the jetty in the green sea, you would realize that it was a large enclosed garden in the middle of the village. In an enclosed garden you stand still and look at the space of which you form part, and it feels like a temporary abode. The meadow evoked a perception like that experienced in a Japanese garden.

School classes and amateur painting clubs were invited to take the village edge as their subject of creativity. The local newspaper, radio, internet newspaper and television station interviewed the artists and informed them about the ups and downs of spatial planning in Heino. Over a period of two months, Andre Dekker spent his weekends receiving passing visitors and inviting them to paint, observe and take photographs. He was motivated by a desire to record by purely verbal and photographic means what an observation post yields by way of observations.

The perceptions of all passers visitors about the village, the village edge and the surrounding landscape were noted. It turned out that no one expressed an opinion about the space in its own right, but in every case took a specific view of the community. Space or a view of space is a mental/cultural phenomenon. The personal observation of Dekker was that the meadow is for most people a symbol of rural tranquillity, a welcome emptiness in the bustle of country life, which upholds its interdependence with the town by means of a huge volume of traffic. Nearly everyone in Heino likes their surroundings, but they all depend in some way on the nearest town. Amid all the issues of spatial planning, it would be easy to miss the fact that *Villagescape* turned a poorly visible, ill-defined open space, used for cattle

grazing, into a field fringed with oak trees that provides repose and tranquillity, simply by making it accessible and offering an optimal viewpoint. This was the suggestion of the temporary work of art: to protect the villagescape, you have to appreciate the place from which it is viewed.
OBSERVATIONS
Heino, as narrated and painted by Heino.

The woman with the tired but twinkling eyes, who reports on events in the village and attends the press conference of the mayor and councillors weekly. The mayor has been relieved of his office and chaos reigns.

The man with the round head in brightly-coloured sports gear, who is please to absorb the scene, although running takes a higher priority.

The neighbour of *Villagescape* and her son come to look. They keep their front yard and the part of the street before their house constantly clean, and make sure that everything around *Villagescape* is kept tidy.

The retired couple who read about *Villagescape* in the newspaper. They live in a block of flats behind the retirement home. They are pleased that their son has taken over the cattle, but they visit once in a few weeks. They are satisfied with everything. They had space and quiet, and now they have nearness and convenience.

The woman with the wickerwork basket who says that the villagescape has become less important to the authorities since Heino merged with Heino. A nearby schoolmaster's house had been demolished, trees in a beech avenue had been felled and an disproportionately large new house had been built. She had always wanted to go into the meadow some day.

The man with a bag full of painting materials, who, after examining the pavilions, said he would like to make a picture. He spends the whole day in *Villagescape*, making watercolours of his visions of tower blocks, oil wells, boulevards and motorways in Heino. His images include a plane crash and a Rietveld House next to the church.

The woman with the black dog, who lives in the white house opposite, says "I was at home thinking about the meadow and *Villagescape*." She deplores the level of street lighting around the meadow, which has risen over the years. The work of art is in her view well camouflaged.

The woman with the cameraman who asks questions: why, why and how? She thinks Heino is pretty, friendly and a bit dull.

The big building worker from round the corner, who knows that hefty underground pumps keep the area of the meadow drained of excess water. He won many prizes for his drawings when he was a boy, built his own house on Saturdays, and believes I am frittering away his taxes. He thinks it is rubbish.

The man who enters the *Villagescape* with a primed canvas and says he doesn't like the painted view of Heino. He wonders how to express ideas in a painting. "I am a socialist at heart, and I would like to see facilities for the less well-off here."

The woman with blue eyes and a tanned face, and her daughter who is keen to appear on the catwalk. Painting is a waste of time, she says. Mother disagrees but says that the meadow is worthless.

The man in the long black coat believes there would be no harm in building on the meadow. What's the point of this place? You have to go round it and there is nothing to justify it. You can't see anything. It would be a good place to build some nice, large houses.

The dignified lady who proposes creating a place of tranquillity in the middle of the meadow, a retreat like the one in Taizé. A place to contemplate your life.

The former head of spatial planning for Overijssel pays a complement. He is amused and notes that the Care Hotel on the meadow needs more articulation, and that nothing else must happen here.

The woman with the narrow face says that the trees you can see from the meadow are lovely. Then she adds that you normally drive past the meadow and then you are under the trees instead of viewing them from afar.

The white-haired couple know everything about *Villagescape* from the press, and declare their point of view: "We are very pleased with the meadow. It is unique and always attractive with the trees around it." The man speaks his own mind: the meadow isn't rectangular like the fields with rationalized boundaries. It is too small for efficiency, which is essential to the feeling.

The neighbour who sells honey from his own hives describes what used to be on the fenced-off meadow: a fairground, marquees, an agricultural show, cattle inspections and temporary houses for the old fold while the home was being remodelled.

The man with a big camera is peeved that something like this, without the least usefulness or good intention, could be built in front of his house. He calls it the Terror of Art. He takes photographs of the interesting way light strikes the frosted windows, and posts his photos and his writings about the Terror of Art on a website.
The couple from Amsterdam. The man keeps his hands in his pockets and observes everything keenly, while the woman photographs everything from different angles. Observatorium has pulled it off again, they say.

The man with curly red hair interprets *Villagescape* as modern art. He fails to see the value of the meadow, since it is dominated by that big white building.

The couple in their Sunday best point out that ley lines intersect under the church of Heilo. These concentrate both good and bad energy.

"I wish it wasn't necessary to build any more new houses," the lady in yellow gloves sighs. I have come back to leave my thoughts behind me and bring my husband with me; he is an urban planner in Zwolle.

The sweet young couple say it should be kept as it is. And this installation can stay here for the while.

The church stewardess likes the way the meadow is being put to use. She is responsible for managing the meadow on behalf of the Reformed Church, and in her opinion *Villagescape* should stay.

The cheerful couple describe how the residents were invited to choose one of three development models for the Salland district around Heino: increased business activities, country estates or villages

with increased population density. They opted for the last of these. But there was another proposal for building on the meadow, and the local business people were very much in favour of it.

The theologist/sociologist thinks that his Reformed congregation would like to congregate at *Villagescape*. They have open minds.

The quiet man with a mustache arrives by car, looks around briefly, says “I can’t see anything” and departs.

The urban planner pictures a maze of hedges and pools on the meadow, together with grazing cattle. His wife reminds him that it would clash with his preference to preserve the meadow as an open field. “I can imagine something, can’t I?” he chuckles.

Chapter 11
Stasis and Movement

Epicentre
Krasnoyarsk, Cultural Historical Museum Complex, 2008

Stasis and Movement
Space for speed is always surrounded by slow space. These spaces are usually separated as much as possible. Observatorium promotes sculpture that links these spaces together and creates opportunity for observation.

"If we go deeper into daydreams of nests, we soon encounter a sort of paradox of sensibility. A nest – and this we understand right away – is a precarious thing, and yet it sets us to daydreaming of security. [...] When we examine a nest, we place ourselves at the origin of confidence in the world."
Gaston Bachelard, *The Poetics of Space*, 1958

Invitation
Sergey Kovalesky, a curator at the Cultural Historical Museum complex in Krasnoyarsk, Siberia, happend on some photographs of *Villagescape in Heino* on the internet. Seeing the observation post gave him the idea of inviting Observatorium to Krasnoyarsk for "a reflection of the Siberian vertical after scanning the Dutch horizontal". He offered an opportunity to take part in the *Tunguska Phenomenon* exhibition, asking specifically for "a pavilion on the area near our museum from which it is possible 'to see' the sky with a centenary trace of light of a mysterious space body." The year 2008 marked the one hundredth anniversary of the famous Tunguska impact. An area of Siberian taiga forest measuring over 2,000 square kilometers was flattened by the blast. Huge amounts of matter spread into the upper atmosphere, scattering so much light that Londoners could read The Times in the street at night. Most accounts of the event describe it as the impact of a meteorite or asteroid, although no fragments have ever been found; more recent analyses point towards a comet. The longer the event recedes into the past, the more conjectures and stories circulate about it. The organizers in Krasnoyarsk wished to hold a scientific symposium and an art exhibition to highlight the effect of the Tunguska event on our culture and beliefs.

Meteor
The museum of the city of Krasnoyarsk, designed by the architect A.S. Demirkhanov, looks like a red meteor resting on a steep riverbank at the place where the first wooden houses and palisades of the original fort once stood. On completion in 1987, the museum was dedicated entirely to the honour of Lenin. Within a few years it had turned into gallery for contemporary art, and was holding an international biennial. The building is a hexagonal behemoth sunk partly into the ground, with staircases that pass underneath it and lead to the river. It has few windows and the gallery spaces are disposed around a huge atrium. the museum is located in a small park, which is connected to the central shopping street Mira by a bridge over the city motorway. A visitor will be struck by two strange discrepancies – that between the museum's prominent site by the river and its isolation by the motorway, and that between its intimidating exterior and the wealth of architectural invention of its interior.

Location
The commissioned work was to be a pavilion for observing the Siberian sky which exploded one hundred years ago. Observatorium quickly found a fitting location, with maximum visibility from the highway and surrounding buildings, with the museum in the background. The city planner had imposed rigorous boundaries here, and there is something to be said for having a mseum with a leisure park and statuary

separated from traffic roads. However, the building and its surroundings, which have so much of interest when viewed from close up, make a purely lifeless impression in the few seconds available to a passing motorist. Observatorium did not wish the pavilion to have the effect of drawing more attention to the museum; the aim was to give balanced recognition to fast and slow perception. We have become habituated to perceiving our world while we hurtle through it. The gaze of the motorist should not be denigrated as a second-class kind of attention. The motorway is not only a domain of speed and engrossment in driving, but also an elongated standpoint from which we perceive and evaluate the world. The work was a modest attempt to connect the slow realm of the museum to the fast one of racing traffic.

Preconditions and symbols
Logistics and the financial conditions for participation in the Tunguska exhibition meant that the pavilion had to be built by the museum carpenter without Observatorium's intervention or supervision. The artists therefore decided to return to the simple construction of using bookcase modules, last applied to making a Dwelling for Seclusion in 1998. The tried and trusted modules were subjected to two modifications. Firstly, the bookcases now consisted only of uprights and shelves, without a back panel; the outlook would thus vary in effective transparency as the observer changes in position, in the same way as a vertical blind on a window allows a passer-by to see into the interior or not as the angle of view changes. Secondly, the bookcases were placed at a tilt on a wide staircase, so that the user's gaze would always be drawn towards the sky whether sitting, lying or standing. These simple measures introduced a dynamic into the act of gazing for the user (in the sculpture) and the spectator (outside the sculpture) [??]; and this was a location around which traffic continually roared through a sharp bend in the motorway.

A byproduct of the unavoidable simplicity was the lovely paradox and symbolism of an open-air study area. The bookcases framed the view but also provided storage for the user's findings, a chaise-longue permitted observation of the sky in comfort, and a table-top was satisfactory for taking notes and making speeches (the last being a nod to Lenin). The bare tree trunks were the simplest way to elevate the study area, and conveyed an incidental reference to the taiga forest flattened in the Tunguska event, a few hundred kilometres away in the direction indicated by the sculpture. The spacing, height and number of tree trunks were decided by the curator.

Use
From a distance, the sculpture projected a simple but appealing, exuberant image. Both the artists and museum called on the public to make use of *Epicentre*, thereby forming the living counterpart of the author Astafjev, whose statue stood high on a plinth one hundred metres away in the park. A study area was provided in the museum for the findings. Everyone knew of the Tunguska event, and was welcome to write stories about it and so become the temporary epicentre of the exhibition. But this part of designing at a distance was unsuccessful, and the museum was unable to arouse enthusiasm for the idea in the absence of the artists. The five local television broadcasts about Observatorium, *Epicentre* and Tunguska were of no avail. Gardens cannot exist without gardeners, so it is questionable how study areas can be said to exist without "scholars".

[contributed article]
Face to Face
Sergei Kovalevski, 2008

The entrance gate creates a delicate symbolic effect. It activates the architectural border along the whole perimeter of the lawn. It seems that the invisible transparent outline of the lawn forms a gigantic hall, inside which there are three smaller halls, like in a Chinese puzzle.

Such a paradoxical topologicalo mechanism, triggered by the key correlation between open and closed, is perfectly revealed in all functional and motional dimensions. The doubling principle works at the podium entrance as well. When the foreground of the three black boxes superimposes the nearest building line, they look like a diminished image of the village silhouette. As if a shadow has lost its contact with the owner.

As a result a captivating play of introspection - a triple pavilion, designed as a device for perception of the rural view, may at the same time be presented as the village alter ego and the plastic formula of its internal structure. After all, the village opens like a fan from the point where the installation is placed. What makes them especially akin is the structural axis of the whole composition – the walkway, which rhymes with the driveway that leads from the village to the highway. Thus before entering the village and melting into the dwelling zone, you are invited to get acquainted and make contact with the village image. The artists managed to create a topological extract from the internal space of the settlement to welcome the visitors.

Providing a panoramic view of Heino's borders, the architectural-optical instrument shows the main obsession of the Dutch – an endless flatness of the fields (and as an invariant, the sea). This studio for projecting a residential environment on the rural landscape materializes the introjection of the horizon. The horizontal perception of the world in the country where there are no jungles, mountains or wild animals, forms an archetypical impression of harmony with Nature. Dutch happiness is horizontal.

Minimalist abstract sculpture appears to be open to the play of associations, and a bodily-visual metaphor is one of the most acute of these. According to the authors, when somebody finds himself inside the black cube he gets an impression of being inside an eye. And the stretching walkway is the long optical nerve connecting the eye with the village body. "We have built the eyes for seeing and for being seen. We created temporary architecture as a zone of non-differentiation between the subject and the object."

In essence, the lawn observatory is a probe or endoscope which intrudes into and reveals the collective body of the village. Since the work was done by the real artists it was natural to them to look for the investigation and communication methods in *plein-air* traditions. As a local historical basis they unearthed an attractive, interesting painting by P. Visser, *Villagescape of Heino*, painted from nature in 1875. The main feature of the picture is the dynamic wave-like surface of the ploughed field receding from the feet of an observer to the perspective horizon. Over one hundred years later, the foundation for the three artist's studios was built, in what can be identified as the same location.

First of all, the friends-artists were invited. They started by organizing a micro-exhibition of sketches made at the location. In addition to the architecture this action stimulated the general public to observe and think about the three-dimensional form and identity of their village and the surrounding land. The easels scattered over the deck super-code the architectonic sculpture into a set of volumetric "frames of art" for further clipping of the landscape energetics. We may see this asis a typical aspect of the Dutch character, especially if we remember Vermeer with his camera obscura, and Van Gogh framing the scene a wooden rectangle when painting outdoors.

A later outlook on outdoor painting (evident in Cubism) entailed the inversion of open into closed. Three cubic flasks pumped the *plein air* inside. The effect is doubled or even tripled – "cubed" life-giving rural air. These are the samples of clean air, which may also be misty: when the glasses weep due to interior heating (the rooms are equipped with autonomous air-heaters). Sometimes the mist fills the outside fields, and then the transparency concentrates inside the cube. The Observatory workers, in cooperation with the climatic conditions, transfer the air from one glass into another as if liquid. The outcome of this "distillation" is a bracing and refreshing extract of something valuable and identifiable. Maybe this is the quintessence of the ensemble?

Cautiously and tenderly, the long, narrow platform hovers over the soil without touching the grass. Its cross shape is a reference to the nearby Protestant cemetery. One can watch the grass growing from this platform. This is the walkway for foot processions, a bridge from the past to the future. In one science-fiction novel about time travel, a traveller to the past had to avoid crushing a butterfly, for otherwise he could have disrupted the whole future chain of reason and consequences. If the human urge for temporary voyeurism can not be eliminated, it is necessary to preserve at least a sense of fear in people. A certain similarity of the crucifix to a well-known garden tool yields a light-hearted proverb: "If you must step on the rake, but do it carefully".

The dynamic foreground with three lenses, through which subjects and objects look at each other from different angles, directs an observer along the power lines of world empathy. Based on such cases of inter-convertibility and recognition, advanced philosophers insist that the landscape is a correlate of great importance to everyone.

The Dutch observers of the adjacent space succeeded in developing an optical mechanism to dictate the angle of view and so control appreciation of the landscape.

[chapter 13]

The Hague, 2009
Antonello da Messina
Observations of the Present State, Stroom, The Hague (with Bram Esser)

Antonello da Messina
The patron saint of Observatorium is St. Jerome, as pictured in his study by Antonello da Messina: solitude in open view, contemplation as a feature of public space. The clash between concentration and civility is confusing and fruitful.

[contributed article]
The Beauty of Misunderstanding
Bram Esser

"Would you like to be a scout for us?" The question, posed to him three months ago, sounded at the time like a simple, offhand request. What had to be scouted out, and why, was as yet unspoken. "It's about art in the public space, in the Netherlands and in Germany, but it's crucial that you know as little as possible about the artists." To the potential scout, this sounded like a job that could end up in countless misunderstandings; and, since he held the opinion that a misunderstanding may lead to something beautiful, he immediately gave his assent.

A list of geographical and topographical coordinates was all he had to work from. Taking the list, he set off by car or by bicycle as appropriate. He proceeded systematically; he was determined to complete the whole list. The scout met people, to whom he posed innocent questions and from whom he received innocent answers. Sometimes it might be someone who was about to go base-jumping, another time the person opened the door half-naked, and in one case the person had a horrible cut on his cheek. When they asked what he wanted, the scout replied, "Hello, I have come to check on the present situation." It sounded reassuring, like the kind of thing an local official or a meter reader might say. He found his way into their home and household without difficulty, and was sometimes treated to a cup of coffee and a biscuit. Like a meter reader, the scout did not stay for long; he would at most brush his hand over the wall and ask to use the toilet – not because he needed to go, but because facts are to be found everywhere if ones eyes are open. The scout grew into his role, and collected facts the way some people collect packages of sugar or coffee creamer. His baggage included a deflated balloon, a stick

chewed by a dog, some beer cans, a flattened frog from the road and the backrest of a chair. Occasionally, he felt a chill of anxiety: was it all pointless, was this merely a mass of junk, random objects discarded along his route? But the scout fought his doubts and constantly reminded himself that he was the boss of the collected facts and not vice versa. He had to drill and discipline the facts like reluctant soldiers, so that they would stand up in formation in the battle against reality. But was he really in control? Wasn't he just a miserable pawn in a game his principals were playing? The scout's mood swung repeatedly between a sense of power and utter powerlessness. It was not until he found himself in a prison that the intention of the artists on whose instructions he was performing his researches dawned on him. There, among the young delinquents, everything fell into place. It was the same intention as on the misty slag heap in the former industrial zone of Essen, as in the inexorable flatness of the Groningen countryside, as on the moto-cross tracks of the Wadden Islands and now in this institution for juvenile offenders: they were trying to become invisible. Admittedly some low walls could be seen, like the foundations of a ruin, but the blue paint that had originally coated them had long peeled away. The few adhering flakes were silent witnesses to their absence. What remained was a gesture, an invitation to other people to make something of it.

Having completed his list, the scout returned to his home base to rendezvous with his principals and report to them as agreed. They had not been idle, in the meanwhile, but had been building. "We have built a study room for you," they said. It was the location where the scout was now expected to spend two months writing up his findings. Once again, the request sounded offhand and innocent. But now the scout was entering a space far more hazardous than all the places he had visited on his travels through Europe. It looked harmless at first sight, but the new space was sown with zones of darkness and dangerous fracture lines – fracture lines which in retrospect seemed to run through the scout himself. In the open field he had been primarily an explorer, and sometimes felt happy with his work. Here, he was half host and half studying monk; half exhibition builder and half spectator; both storyteller and observer.

By the time the consequences of this situation dawned on him, his principals had vanished, as they invariably did. He was on his own, and he would have to fill the space with his own presence if necessary. It was a responsibility which alarmed him and which confronted him with many questions about himself and his function. He would approach visitors as they entered, wringing his hands: "Please understand, the exhibition is still under construction," he would say in hushed tones, "Just see it as a stage in a process." What kind of process that was, the scout was not quite sure. His concern and embarrassment about the emptiness prompted him to start filling in spaces of his own accord. In a way that recalled how farmers used to prop up a dilapidated barn with sticks and stones from his land, the scout could boost his self-confidence once he took to introducing materials found in the vicinity. He improvised a living room, where he could invite visitors to stay a little longer than would be usual for an art gallery, in the middle of the space. The scout also began creating a garden. He made it into a pleasing visual spectacle which would reassure the visitor that this was, indeed, an art exhibition. No audience is as well conditioned as that of art lovers. The scout's coloured plastic bottle tops looked like art, but it wasn't that at all: it was a flowery garden of misunderstanding. The scout, originally appointed to clarify or at least draw attention to matters for the benefit of visitors, became a specialist in blurring the boundaries. Several new doubts were added to the heap of questions that already occupied him. Who or what was this exhibition actually about? What were the limits of proper behaviour? Was this some kind of retrospective show? If asked, the scout would deny that he was blurring any boundaries: "I am simply accentuating the fracture lines that are already here, and I will explain it in my report," he would say. "Besides, this has nothing to do with recognizing the past, but it looks solely towards the future."

Ladies and gentlemen, the artists are now not the only ones who have vanished from the work. So has the scout. You can enter his domain and examine the traces he has left behind, just as he previously examined the traces left by users of your "observatories" in the field. He lived there, slept

there, wrote and tended the garden. But from today onwards, he will no longer be there to guide people through your archives. Henceforth you can do it yourselves.

[mottos]

01. Time and space for attention
Art needs the spectator. “Time and space for attention” means that the spectator must be given ample time and space to be with the work of art. The exhibition space takes on the character of a dwelling. It is an opportunity to give rise to meaning in a long, undisturbed stay.

02. Otium – Negotium
An *Observatory* is a paradoxical space into which you can withdraw in order to define your relationship to the world. Perception of the surroundings is impossible without an additional inward gaze. Solitude is a form of participation.

03. Connecting separate worlds
Observatorium takes a stand against the fragmentation of the world into separate zones for work, leisure, transport, shopping, housing, nature and waste. Observatorium rejects the boundaries of the separate worlds and uses them to establish connections.

04. Civilization is maintenance
Observatorium makes works of art that are unfinished, so that they grow in time. Civilization is not a moment in time but a process. Maintenance is part of the development, not of the status quo.

05. The work of art is not finished until someone uses it
Observatorium is fond of a lively scene and is appreciates it if people expand or tinker with their projects and sculptures. The basis for a public sculpture is established by a claim on space. The basis for a lively public space is appropriation by people.

06. Use paradox
Dirt, conflict and stupidity are the opposites of beauty, harmony and civilization. Art does not choose among these, but worms its way between them and makes proposals for the coexistence of good and evil.

07. A sculpture is ideally three things
A sculpture is preferentially three things: a work of imagination, a reflection on the surroundings and a component of communality. It is there to be accepted and experienced. It discloses the nature of the surroundings and instigates action.

08. The world, as it is described
Observatorium makes works of art for observation of the world and for observation of the individual. The sum of all findings that people utter at the location is an adequate representation of the infinite complexity of the world, including ourselves.

09. Design what is there
Emptiness and silence are hard to design. When these are present, Observatorium incorporates them into its designs. There are three methods: doing nothing, protecting and making visible.

10. Cella, courtyard, domain
Diversity of space creates curiosity and diversity of use. The sequence cella, courtyard and domain phases the fluid connections between inside and outside. Private and public are established by consultation.

11. Stillness and motion
Someone who designs for mobility takes account of the person who observes others moving. Observatorium favours sculpture that both complements the space and creates an opportunity for observation. The plinth is there for people.

12. Exhibiting is producing
The museum is a productive place for displaying what has been acquired, for compiling it and for preparing new impulses. The exhibition does not consist only of the objects and the spectators, but also the proposals and the compilers.

13. Antonello da Messina
The patron saint of Observatorium is St. Jerome in his study, as portrayed by Antonello da Messina: solitude in public, contemplation as part of public space. The conflict between concentration and courtesy is confusing and fruitful.

Observatorium Project List 1995–2009
(selection)

Geert van de Camp (1961), Andre Dekker (1956), Ruud Reutelingsperger (1962)

1994/1995 Rotterdam, Groningen, Düsseldorf
De Vaalserberg, Rotterdam; Ziegler, Groningen; O.S.O. Düsseldorf
34 people spent a night in an Observatory in the gallery, and left a record of their findings. The interior consisted of soft woollen blocks, paintings and texts. Travelling exhibition.

1997 Berlin
Autorenwerkstatt [Authors' Workshop], Peking Kunstausstellungen, Berlin
Nine authors from Berlin (including Katrin Dorn, Antje Strubl and Durs Grünbein) used Observatory Berlin as a public working place, and left a record of their findings.

1997 New York
Dwelling for Seclusion, Snug Harbor Cultural Center, Staten Island, New York
45 people each stayed for 24 hours in a sculpture consisting of modular bookcases in the park, and left a record of their findings.

1997 New York
Collected Reflections, Art in General, New York
Archive of collected findings from the *Dwelling for Seclusion*

1998 Klaaswaal
Hoeksche Waard Observatory, Klaaswaal, Architecture International Rotterdam
42 people each spent 24 hours in a pavilion consisting of modular bookcases in Hoeksche Waard and left a record of their findings; part of the AIR/Southbound festival.

1998 Rotterdam
Collected Findings, Villa Alckmaer, Centrum Beeldende Kunst, Rotterdam
A temporary pavilion of modular bookcases in a city garden, which serves as an archive of *Collected Findings* from Hoeksche Waard.

1999 New York
Netherland NY – Polder for Seclusion in New York Bay, Frederieke Taylor Gallery, New York
Proposal for a new polder dedicated to tranquillity and solitude in New York Bay, with 30 layout proposals by designers.
2000 Groningnen
Open Plan Office, Centrum Beeldende Kunst, Groningen
Office furniture for students, on plinths in Noorderplantsoen city park.

2001 Rotterdam
Nieuw Terbregge Observatory, Proper-Stok Woningen, dS+V, Rotterdam
Enclosed garden of recycled asphalt with pavilion and lookout point made of crash barriers, on sound bund alongside A20 Motorway.

2002 Delft
Motorway Nest, Sculptures in Autumn, Delft

Steel sculpture with birds and car tyres on an advertising mast alongside the A13 motorway (collab. Interbest, Breda).

2002 Berlin
Woher kommen die Löcher im Konzept? [Where Do the Holes in the Concept Come From?], Galerie Wohnmaschine, Berlin
Asphalt interior, functioning as a model-building workshop, for artist Mirjam Kuitenbrouwer, in context of World Architecture Congress.

2002 Ulm
Moonpalace, Stadthaus, Ulm
Landscape of 5,000 cardboard boxes for a camera house by artist Mirjam Kuitenbrouwer, in the "white box" architecture of Richard Meijer, in *Unheim* exhibition, dedicated to *Anarchitekturen*.

2003 Hoogezand
Otium Leinewijk, Semslinie Art Line, Hoogezand
Sculpture, amendable to extension and modification, on loan to a private individual, in former peat lands near Groningen; the sculpture serves as a dwelling for seclusion, rest and study, and forms a gateway to the landscape.

2003 Vught
Government buildings Agency, *Plein voor De Leij*, De Leij Judicial Juvenile Institution, Vught.
Design of a plaza for inmates, personnel and visitor to a youth prison on the site of a wartime concentration camp. Brickwork foundations are built by inmates for the purposes of practical education, play, animal sheds, vegetable-growing and good conversation.

2003 Rotterdam
Hotel Diorama, Motel Mozaique, Rotterdam
Fifteen shops in a street combine to form a hotel with a lobby, breakfast room and fourteen bedrooms for festival guests, who stay overnight in a shop window.

2003 Dresden
Melancholie und die Braut, art and urban design festival, Postplatz, Dresden
Temporary open air theatre on busy traffic island, consisting of a platform of Dresden sandstone, *Plattenbau* (prefabricated concrete) slabs, a red bed and 400 seats.

2003 The Hague
Hoftoren Open Plan Office, Government Buildings Agency, The Hague
Outdoor office space for 24 people in the internal garden of a building, design by Kohn-Pedersen-Fox. Ministry of Education, Culture and Science, The Hague.

2003 Puttershoek
Fence for Hoeksche Waard, Province of Zuid-Holland, The Hague
South Holland Landscape Prize in the form of a steel fence with lines of verse, functioning as a high-class entrance to a landscape dominated by creeks.

2003 Delft
Da Azuren Sanatorium, "350 Years of Delft Blue Pottery" exhibition, Delft. "Sanatorium" consisting of 13 blue/white beds under blue trees, for VINEX estate residents in an old orchard (with Noëlle Cuppens).

2003 Neukirchen-Vluyn
Mount of Silence, Landschaftspark Niederrhein, Neukirchn-Vluyn, conversion of a coal slag heap into a recreational amenity in the Ruhr (collab. WES+Partner, Hamburg).

2003 Milan
Alphalto, Milan Triennale
Participation in exhibition on the history and artistic applications of asphalt in urban design and landscape archtitecture.

2004 Amersfoort
Parkpodium Vathors, Heijmans Bouwbedrijf, Ontwikkelingsbedrijf Vathorst, Amersfoort
Open air stage made of four concrete domestic floors with four different ceramic patterns, steel frames and 300 seats; memorial to pioneering phase of new housing etate.

2004 Zuid-Beijerland
Bolwerk Beijerland, "Dichterbij de Molen" Poetry Festival, Zuid-Beijerland
Temporary sculpture referring to the struggle of Hoeksche Waard against urbanization, consisting of a theatre space of 100 apple boxes on hydraulically raised land in a riverside private garden.

2005 Rotterdam
Studio for Family Portrait, Dora Dolz, Rotterdam
Glass house for a large painting with a wooden frame that encloses both the painting and the studio; used for production of film *Portrait of Dora Dolz*.

2005 Essen
Zollvereinpark, Entwicklungsgesellschaft Zollverein, Essen
Park design for Zeche Zollverein Unesco World Heritage Site, preserving "industrial nature"; includes size entrance pavilions (collab. Planergruppe Oberhausen, Firstdesign and Licht Kunst Licht)

2005 Culemborg
The Memory of Parijsch, Ontwikkelingsmaatschappij Parijsch, Culemborg
Steel shed as landmark for the shopping centre of the Parijsch district, with an attic containing 13,000 copies of *Culemborgse Courant* (a newspaper written by Observatorium) which was distributed in 2025. Wooden decks frame a controversial road barrier with traffic lights and can theoretically enclose them. (Both projects in collaboration with Sjaak Langenberg)

2005 Rotterdam
Gold Fever, Rotterdam Fesitvals, Rotterdam
Organization and layout of a commercial exhibition to promote collaboration between the Rotterdam cultural and business sectors, in an arena of stairways and tribunes in the Beurs/WTC Building.

2005 Utrecht
Leidsche Rhenus, Netherlands Architecture Fund, Rotterdam. Study towards a development strategy to integrate and commercially exploit archeological finds in the Leidsche Rijn VINEX new town, in collaboration with Kees Christiaanse Architecten en Planners.

2006 Groningen
Meerstad Crater, Centrum Beeldende Kunst, Dienst Landelijk Gebied, Groningen

Group exhibition intended to inspired urban design in Meerstad, a new town near Groningen. Proposal: construct a landscape of volcanos, in a lake of building and domestic waste on the natural gas extraction site.

2006 Heijplaat
RDM Expo Circuit/Boathouse, Stadshavens, Rotterdam
Study for floating arrival/departure hall in the docks of the former RDM Wharf, for which schools and knowledge/innovation industries are planned; including routing for wharf and surroundings (in collaboration with Arcadis, Woonbron and Sul Beheer).

2006 Rotterdam
Manna Monument, Ontwikkelingsbedrijf Rotterdam, Proper-Stok Group and Terbregge Residents Association.
Monument memorializing the food drops in Rotterdam in 1945, consisting of hundreds of steel boxes that together form the fuselage of an aircraft, including plaque and flagpole. Placed in Nieuw Terbregge Observatory.

2006 Dresden
Wild Capital, Kunsthaus Dresden
Participation in group exhibition on the influence of capital on society; 9 tin casts of brains, in an open bank safe.

2006 Neukirchen-Vluyn
Hallenhaus, Regional Verband Ruhr, Essen
Steel sculpture on a coal slag heap alongside the A57 Autobahn in the Ruhr. The hall is 16 metres long, 14 wide and 10 high. It is a landmark, a place of tranquillity and a historical reference. It is also the main building of the Open Air University, an educational programme by Observatorium.

2007 Rotterdam
Dear Malcolm, Artstore, Rotterdam
Participation in a group exhibition by the curator Goan Lim, presenting Rotterdam artists working abroad. Photographs of the *Hallenhaus* in Germany and a letter to M. Kirk, owner of the Dutch Barn in New York State, on which Observatorium's *Hallenhaus* was modelled.

2007 Werkendam
Panoramapark, Noord-Brabantse Kunststichting, Breda
The Ministry of Transport (Rijkswaterstaat) plans to widen the A27 motorway to form a panoramic route, but the projected track transects the Fort Altena heritage site, part of the Holland Water Defense Line. Obersvatorium proposes duplicating the fort, according the surrounding area park status and building a connecting bridge as a landmark.

2007 Essen
Zollvereinpavilion, LEG, Dortmund
The first of a series of entrance pavilions for the Unesco for the Zeche Zollverein Unesco World Heritage Site. The materials and dimensions of the coal industry combined with the layout and intimacy of an artisan's cottage; house, garden and stall made of steel and concrete.

2007 Basel
Instant Urbanism, Schweizerisches Architektur Museum, Basel.

Nieuw Terbregge Observatory submitted to an exhibition on architecture and art associated by the curator Francesca Ferguson with the Situationist International.

2007 Rotterdam
Perron Mozaique, Motel Mozaïque and Hofbogen, Rotterdam
A station platform built with scaffolding and purple floor covering, with three wooden sleeping cabins, on Hofplein Station. The platform rises in steps to a height of 13 metres. Location for a popular music festival, debate, overnight stays, breakfast and a view of an incomplete city..

2008 Rotterdam
PowerPoint Rotterdam, 3rd Architecture Biennial, Rotterdam.
The walls of the Berendsen Gallery were built using metal stud into the interior of the café/restaurant De Unie, producing a space within a space. Large plaster panels bearing photographs of Observatorium projects were mounted on the aluminium columns.

2008 Heino
Villagescape, Heino, Province of Overijssel and KCO, Zwolle
Three observational pavilions and nine painters' easels on an elevation in a meadow in the centre of the village. The installation was inspired by a pointing dating from 1859 and a workshop for villagescapes, and was constructed in situ by 9 amateurs and several classes of schoolchildren. Observatorium observed the users and reported their findings.

2008 Rotterdam
Paradetraverse, De Parade Theatre Festival and Netherlands Architecture Institute, Rotterdam.
A 650-metre long "catwalk", 5 metres high in places, above the Parade site, the building excavations in Museumpark and through the building of the Netherlands Architecture Institute, for seeing and being seen. Including a programme on urban development.

2008 Deventer
Middenin, Kunstenlab, Deventer.
A resting point for walkers and cyclists in the middle of the meadows, also serving as a drinking and sheltering place for cattle. Forms part of a recreational network.
2008 Terschelling
Shared Domains, National Forestry Department and Oerol, Terschelling.
Design and development plan for a disused landfill site: a table mountain with a crater, at the disposal of to nature, seaside visitors and theatre makers.

2008 Apeldoorn
On the Road, BVKB Fund, Apeldoorn
Theatre with approx. seats for debates and presentations, in conjunction with Apeldoorn Landscape Triennial, in the form of an American parkway, consisting of 220 tons of waste asphalt from the Media Park in Harlem.

2008 Krasnoyarsk
Epicentre, Cultural Historical Museum Complex, Krasnoyarsk.]
A study cell with chaise longue, cupboards and a lectern, on a foundation of 14 upward-sloping tree trunks, alongside a museum showing an exhibition on the mythology of the world's greatest meteor impact in the Earth's recent history, Tunguska.

2008 Venice
Pausa, Architecture Biennale, Venice.
A terrace on a canal behind the emergency exit of the Italian pavilion was transformed into an open air museum. Bench seats with views of the rear of the Biennale and of a 19 metre long photograph depicting 10 years of Observatorium.

2009 Rotterdam
Make Space, Yourworld09, Netherlands Architecture Institute, Rotterdam.
Exhibition and participation model for reorganizing public space. Designers, clients, neighbourhood managers and young people join in campaigning for a good public square in Rotterdam, using "The Making Of", a spatial planning game by Buro Venhuizen.

2009 Rotterdam
De Bocht, dS+V, Rotterdam.
In connection with remodelling of the Kleinpolderplein intersection, Observatorium proposed turning the motorway complex into a park instead of demolishing it. A flyover for pedestrians and cyclists announced this transition marker. In collaboration with Annemieke Diekman Landschapsarchitecten.

2009 The Hague
Observations of the Present State, Stroom, The Hague.
Retrospective exhibition on the oeuvre of Observatorium. Bram Esser lived in the gallery for six weeks, studying and reporting on his tour of the sculptures and locations where Observatorium has worked.

Lectures
Art in General, New York
Public Art Fund, New York
Zaal De Unie, Rotterdam
Bonnefantenmuseum, Maastricht
Museum für Angewandte Kunst, Cologne
Stadt schafft Landschaft, Potsdam
Urbandrift, Berlin
IVAM, Valencia
Ruhr Universität, Bochum
Koninklijke Academie Beeldende Kunst, The Hague
Hogeschool voor de Kunsten, Utrecht
Visual Seminar, Sofia
Lighthouse Centre for Architecture, Glasgow
Europäisches Haus der Stadtkultur, Gelsenkirchen
Kunsthaus, Dresden
Royal Academy, London
AKI, Enschede
Netherlands Architecture Institute, Rotterdam
Gunpowder Park, London
Koninklijke Academie, 's-Hertogenbosch
Theaterfestival Favoriten, Dortmund
Bijhouwer lecture, De Doelen, Rotterdam
Akademie der Bildenden Künsten, Munich

Workshops

Design Academy, Eindhoven
Technical University, Eindhoven
Fakultät Architektur Universität, Wuppertal
College of Art, Edinburgh
St. Joost Academy, Breda
Cheops, Eindhoven
AKI, Enschede
Universität, Hannover
Technical University, Braunschweig
Technical University, Delft

Prizes

2001
Bauweltpreis, Kategorie Innenräume, for *Dwelling for Seclusion*, New York, awarded by Bauwelt periodical, Berlin

2003
Forever Asphalt Prize, free expression category, for Nieuw Terbregge Observatory, Rotterdam, awarded by VBW Asfalt, Dutch Association of Asphalt Manufacturers